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CMRL CASE

SIT to probe graft claims about Pinarayi

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'India could see 15,800 heat deaths in 6 months'

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ALLEGED TRESPASSING

4 A.P. students die after being run over by train

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NAVIGATING RIVALRIES

A plausible multilateralism

The BRICS offers India a space to pursue strategic autonomy

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MISSION ACCOMPLISHED

Mirabai fulfils her Asian Games dream

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INSIDE



LG, Samsung face tax evasion probe over OLED parts

NEW DELHI

India is investigating LG Electronics and Samsung for allegedly paying lower tariffs on imported display parts of high-end TVs, five sources told Reuters, putting under scrutiny the premium entertainment devices both South Korean giants have bet on. » PAGE 12



IIT Bombay panel will investigate student's death

MUMBAI

IIT Bombay on Wednesday set up a committee with 10 members to probe the circumstances around the death by suicide of Sahil Ravindra Wakode, age 20, a student at the institute, on September 18, 2026. The panel may question Professor Suryanarayana Doolia, who has been named in the case, an official said. Prof. Doolia has been sent on leave. This was to facilitate a probe without bias, sources said. » PAGE 6

8 named in Ram Temple cash theft case chargesheet

LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh Police on Wednesday filed the chargesheet in the Ram Temple cash embezzlement case in Ayodhya before a local court. Eight accused persons have been named in the document which details the sequence of events and findings from a probe into the theft of cash and donations, sources said. » PAGE 5

Opposition seeks CEC's exit for 'illegal conduct'

Gyanesh Kumar under fire after an expose over 'formal objections' by his fellow commissioners

Congress calls for SC-monitored probe; INDIA bloc will meet soon on the issue, says Mamata

The commissioners said decisions were made in the name of the full EC without their knowledge

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Opposition parties on Wednesday sought the removal of Gyanesh Kumar as the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) after an *Indian Express* expose claimed that two of the three members of the Election Commission (EC), Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, had formally recorded objections at least 14 times over the last 10 months. The two commissioners said major decisions were being made in the name of the full EC without their knowledge, many of which they called "unauthorised and illegal". Declaring "vote chori" is a crime against Indian people and a direct attack on the Constitution, the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, said that "the BJP, RSS, and EC who organised it have committed an act of treason. Justice will be served." Under the 2023 law governing the EC, all decisions should be made unanimously where possible. Where the CEC and the commissioners disagree,

Under scanner

The allegations against the CEC come amid widespread complaints about the SIR exercises and apprehensions about the poll body's conduct

KEY ISSUES RAISED

- Centralisation of electoral database
- Alteration of Form 6
- Authorisation of appeals against voter inclusion
- 97 eligible voters from Goa being left out of the roll



Sukhbir Singh Sandhu
Election Commissioner



Gyanesh Kumar
Chief Election Commissioner



Vivek Joshi
Election Commissioner

All official orders, decisions, and administrative directions issued by the commission carry full legal sanctions - EC STATEMENT

Vote chori is a crime... The BJP, RSS, and EC who organised it have committed an act of treason. Justice will be served



RAHUL GANDHI, LoP in Lok Sabha

the majority should prevail, the law says. According to the *Indian Express* report, the two commissioners red-flagged several key issues, led by the centralisation of the database of electoral rolls. In May, Mr. Joshi had reportedly proposed an audit to certify that "no one except the concerned statutory authorities has any credentials to make any change in the data base". Opposition parties asked the Supreme Court to take *suo motu* cognisance of the report and Congress leader K.C. Venu-

gopal demanded a Supreme Court-monitored probe to "expose the rot that has destroyed the EC's credibility". The CEC has no right to remain in office after the expose, he said.

'Stolen mandates'

Former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee said the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance would meet soon to discuss the next course of action, including a *jono jagaran* (public awareness) campaign against "the BJP and its machinery". She also called for re-polls in

West Bengal, Bihar, Haryana, and Madhya Pradesh, saying BJP had not won in these States, but rather the mandates were "stolen".

The EC responded on Wednesday, saying all its actions have been in accordance with the relevant laws. Highlighting specific internal notes spread over a 10-month period while overlooking the larger body of approvals, decisions, instructions, and initiatives gives only "one part of the picture", it said. In August, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu had recorded that State-level election

officials were reporting that they do not have "proper and complete access" to the ERONet portal, the digital system through which the electoral rolls are maintained. He further flagged the Commission's director general of information technology Seema Khanna "does not have any legal authority to restrict proper and complete access and freedom to operate as given by law to the statutory authorities". The *Express* report said that when a new officer was put in charge of the EC's administration divi-

sion in Delhi and issued a work allocation order that threatened to further concentrate these powers, the two ECs separately wrote to the country's top bureaucrat, Cabinet Secretary T.V. Somanathan.

Mr. Sandhu also asked who had authorised the Commission in West Bengal to file appeals against voters whom judicial tribunals had already included in the rolls, with 38 lakh appeals still pending.

The two commissioners also flagged that Form 6 - which new voters must fill to register - was altered to

ask if the applicant or their parents or grandparents "exist" in the electoral roll at the time of the last special intensive revision (SIR). Mr. Joshi had warned as early as May that such a statutory form cannot be changed without amending Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, and Mr. Sandhu had agreed, calling the change "unauthorised and illegal" in August, demanding its immediate removal.

They also flagged the Goa case where 97 voters found eligible by local Electoral Registration Officers after a SC-mandated hearing were left off the final roll because the centrally-controlled software had no mechanism to record the EROs' decision, despite the CEO's office writing eight times to the EC, seeking a rollback option.

The Opposition has already filed two motions in Parliament seeking the removal of the CEC.

EDITORIAL

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SIR IS ILLEGAL: FORMER CEC » PAGE 5

Autumn harvest



Valley's bounty: Farmers work in a paddy field on the outskirts of Srinagar, Kashmir, on Wednesday. Autumn marks the paddy harvesting period in the State. IMRAN NISSAR

India, EU to sign free trade agreement on December 16

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
Suhasini Haider
NEW DELHI

The Free Trade Agreement (FTA) between India and the European Union (EU) will be signed on December 16, two diplomatic sources have separately confirmed to *The Hindu*.

This will be part of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's back-to-back trips in December to Canada, the U.S., and Belgium, where three separate FTAs are currently either being negotiated or in the process of approval.

Further, as the EU FTA has received "majority approval" in Europe, it will not require separate ratification by each EU country once the European Council gives its go-ahead.

The next step, after the signing, will be passage in the European Parliament, which will take another one to two months, paving the way for a roll-out in "early 2027".

"The most recent development was the European Commission finalising the text of the deal and sending it to the European Council," a diplomatic source told *The Hindu*.

"The signing is scheduled for December 16, after which it will go to the European Parliament."

Negotiations on the India-EU FTA, dubbed the "mother of all deals" by leaders on both sides, restarted in June 2022 after a long hiatus and were concluded in January 2026.

Final touches

Negotiations on the India-EU Free Trade Agreement, dubbed the 'mother of all deals', were concluded in January 2026

The FTA will see the EU dropping tariffs on 99.5% of Indian exports to the region, with most tariffs going down to 0%

India will give tariff concessions on 97.5% of the traded value between the two economies

After the signing, the deal will take 1-2 months to pass in the European Parliament, paving the way for an 'early 2027' roll-out



The deal would see the EU dropping tariffs on 99.5% of items India exports to the region, with most tariffs going down to 0% immediately once the agreement comes into effect.

India, on the other hand, has given tariff concessions on 97.5% of the traded value between the two economies.

Signing in Brussels

A second source confirmed the date, adding that it would take place in Brussels in the presence of Prime Minister Modi.

"The deal has majority support in Europe, and so it will not need to be individually ratified in each EU country," the first source added. A reason for this support is that the two sides agreed to leave out contentious issues from the deal and not make "the best the enemy of the good".

Mr. Modi is expected to travel to Canada first, probably around December 12, prior to the G-20 Summit in Miami. Confirming the

visit, Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney said trade negotiations had made "good progress". "Our commitment to each other, PM Modi and myself last year at the G20 (in Canada) was to look to conclude negotiations by G20 of this year (in the U.S.). That's the middle of December, 14-15 December," Mr. Carney said at a briefing in New York on Tuesday.

In an interview with Canada's *Globe and Mail* newspaper, India's High Commissioner to Canada, Dinesh Patnaik, also confirmed the visit, adding that he expected the India-Canada FTA to be "completed by November" and Mr. Modi would be in Canada in December to sign the deal.

Mr. Modi is then expected to attend the G20 meeting in Miami, where the India-U.S. Interim Agreement on trade and a larger Bilateral Trade Agreement (BTA) will also be on the agenda. Both agreements have already missed several deadlines.

We are victims of terror, not terrorists: Pezeshkian

Associated Press
UNITED NATIONS

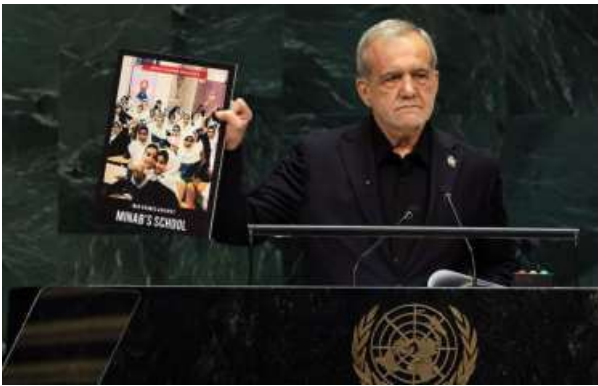
Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian said on Wednesday that his people have been "victims of terrorism" by the United States, delivering a rare wartime speech at UN General Assembly a day after President Donald Trump said he could "annihilate" the Islamic republic.

In a defiant speech, President Pezeshkian held up large photos of the late Supreme Leader Ali Khomeini and the more than 150 Iranian school children killed by U.S. strikes on the first days of the war.

"We have only defended ourselves. We are not ter-

rorists," Pezeshkian said at the General Assembly. "Our innocent people have been the targets of cowardly attacks and aggressions imposed upon our country. And we defended ourselves with utmost strength. America and Israel attacked us."

He added of the United States: "Yes they did hit us, but we did not bend the knee." Toward the end of his speech, Mr. Pezeshkian called out Mr. Trump by name. "It must be understood by Mr. Trump and those who seek to bully us that we are ready for dialogue and diplomacy and negotiations without accepting the language of force."



Masoud Pezeshkian holds up a picture of an Iranian school that was bombed, while speaking at the UN headquarters on Wednesday. AFP

He also said one thing that was measurably false: "We did not hit civilian populations."

Arriving in New York under heavy security and scrutiny, Mr. Pezeshkian -

who, within Iran's political landscape, is considered a moderate politician - addressed world leaders a day after Mr. Trump used the same stage to suggest he may "annihilate" the Is-

lamic Republic if a deal isn't reached soon to end the nearly seven-month war.

Mr. Pezeshkian's address elaborated on where Tehran stands as more than a year of start-stop negotiations between the two longtime adversaries have failed to produce a sustainable solution.

His address last year came months after the 12-day Israel-Iran war.

"Ladies and gentlemen, you all bore witness that this past June, my country was subjected to a savage aggression and flagrant contravention of the most elementary principles of international law," Mr. Pezeshkian said at the time.

INBRIEF



U.P. CM launches Bharat Taxi, loan scheme for farmers

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Wednesday launched the Bharat Taxi service and the Mukhyamantri Krishak Samridhhi Yojana, calling it two major steps for welfare of taxi drivers and farmers of the State. Through Bharat Taxi, two-wheeler, taxi and three-wheeler drivers will be able to join on zero commission upon registration. They will also receive social security of ₹5 lakh. Under the Mukhyamantri Krishak Samridhhi Yojana, the interest rate on loans provided to farmers through the Uttar Pradesh Cooperative Gramya Vikas Bank has been reduced from 11% to 6%.

Mayawati's younger nephew new BSP national convener

The Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) on Wednesday appointed Ishan Anand, younger nephew of party president Mayawati, as its new national convener, days after his elder brother was removed from all party responsibilities. The decision was announced at a meeting of the BSP's national executive held in Lucknow and chaired by Ms. Mayawati. Mr. Anand, who has completed his Master of Laws (LLM), was present at the meeting along with his father and BSP national vice-president Anand Kumar. In his address Mr. Anand thanked the party chief for entrusting him with the responsibility.

Cases withdrawn against 20 booked for Leh violence

L-G announces decision ahead of first anniversary of protests that left four dead; foot marches in Leh and Kargil led by Wangchuk and KDA

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Lieutenant Governor (L-G) Vinai Kumar Saxena on Wednesday announced withdrawal of criminal cases against 20 individuals allegedly involved in last year's September 24 protests over Statehood and Sixth Schedule demands in Ladakh ahead of the first anniversary of the violent stir that left four civilians dead.

"In the larger interest of peace, public tranquillity, and social harmony in Ladakh, I have approved the withdrawal of criminal cases against 20 individuals, related to the unfortunate violence that erupted in Leh on September 24 last year," said Mr. Saxena. He said a comprehensive review was held of the cases, upon which the Ladakh police recommended a closure report for these individuals.

"By prioritising justice and healing over protracted litigation, the decision aims at fostering a more



Cases withdrawn in the larger interest of peace, public tranquillity and social harmony, says L-G Vinai Kumar Saxena. FILE PHOTO

peaceful, united, and harmonious society in Ladakh," said the L-G while thanking Union Home Minister Amit Shah for his "sympathetic approach in matters pertaining to the victims and their families".

Meanwhile, peaceful *padayatra*s (foot marches) were held in Leh and Kargil on Wednesday. Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk led a march in Leh to commemorate those who died in Leh last year. "Civilian volunteers fought for the nation and won huge areas in the 1971 war with Pakistan. People of Ladakh have always stood for the nation

and now it's time the nation stood with Ladakh," said Mr. Wangchuk, who has expressed unhappiness over the Centre not sharing details of the road map for Ladakh's special status under Article 371.

All-faith prayer

The Ladakh Buddhist Association (LBA) will hold an all-faith prayer in memory of those people who died in the firing last year on Thursday. In Kargil, hundreds of supporters of the Kargil Democratic Alliance (KDA), a civil society body, took out a 'Ladakh Justice March'.

T.N. Cong. leader says he told Chennai police about 'Gem' Veeramani scandal 2 years ago

THE HINDU EXCLUSIVE

Udhav Naig
CHENNAI

In a twist to the sensational child sexual abuse case allegedly involving Gem Granites owner R. Veeramani, a Congress leader on Wednesday said he had informed the Chennai police about the crime as early as in November 2024.

The following month, he had also shared with the police a video clip in which a man resembling the octogenarian business magnate was seen abusing a minor girl.

"I met a senior police officer at the Chennai Police Commissionerate in Egmore on November 22, 2024, and submitted a written complaint (dated November 21), seeking action against Veeramani and his associate Shanthi (both now in custody). I also attached screenshots from the video clip," M.P. Ranjan Kumar, president, Tamil Nadu Congress Committee's Scheduled Caste Department, told *The Hindu*.

He shared with this Correspondent a copy of the complaint, which he claimed he had handed ov-



R. Veeramani

er to the senior police officer, as well as screenshots of his conversation with the officer on WhatsApp, seeking his appointment to discuss the issue.

Mr. Kumar's claim contradicts the Chennai police's statement that they had received a complaint and a pen drive of the video of the sexual abuse through an NGO only in October last year.

"The senior officer assured me that action would be taken after conferring with the then Police Commissioner. On November 25, 2024, an Inspector from the Anti-Vice Squad sought information related to the case. On December 17, 2024, I sent him (Inspector) the video clip. Thereafter, I was repeatedly asked if I knew the victims seen in the video. I did

not know them, but I insisted that if the police could summon Veeramani and Shanthi or conduct a surprise raid at their homes, they would be able to retrieve more evidence," he said. Mr. Kumar alleged that the police, however, gradually stopped correspondence with him on the case.

The Congress leader said he was disclosing this as some vested interests were seeking to link him with the scandal, and the police, too, had not acknowledged his role and were now seeking to push back the case by a year, claiming they had received a complaint only last year.

In his complaint, Mr. Kumar had alleged: "Gem Granites proprietor, Veeramani, had been frequenting the residence of Shanthi and had been preying on girl children aged between 14 and 16, particularly belonging to oppressed and minority communities. I had been given the possession of videos that show sexual acts performed by him on girl children..."

He had lodged the complaint "in the hope that the children would be protected".

JD(U) to contest upcoming U.P. poll, eyes 60 Purvanchal seats

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

The Janata Dal (United), a coalition partner of the Bharatiya Janata Party in Bihar, on Wednesday said it would contest the Assembly election in neighbouring Uttar Pradesh next year and preparing to field candidates in 60 seats, particularly in Purvanchal areas, close to the inter-State border where Kurmi and Kushwaha votes are in sizeable number. Towards, this, it will also hold a party workers' meeting in Varanasi on October 25 in which top leaders from Bihar are likely to be present.



JD(U) chief Nitish Kumar with son Nishant Kumar.

Gandhi alias Sanjay Kumar Singh, a senior JD(U) leader and MLC in Bihar who is considered to be a trusted confidant of Mr. Nitish Kumar.

When asked if the party has zeroed in on the seats it plans to contest, Mr. Gandhi indicated that they would be constituencies near the Bihar border but added "it's up to NDA's top leadership to decide in coalition politics".

Other Bihar JD(U) leaders, preferring anonymity,

said the party is eyeing seats where Other Backward Class (OBC) Kurmi and Kushwaha caste voters are in sizeable numbers. Mr. Nitish Kumar is a Kurmi; current Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary comes from the Kushwaha caste.

'No alliance yet'

"Party leaders would discuss how to strengthen the organisational strategy in view of the upcoming Assembly election. We are right now in the process of deliberating on alliance partners but nothing has been finalised yet," said JD (U) U.P. spokesperson Kunwar Ajay Singh. Other JD (U) leaders indicated that BJP is their preferred ally for U.P. as well.

In the previous Assembly election in U.P. in 2022, the JD(U) contested 26 out of the State's 403 seats on its own but won none. The party secured about 0.11% of the total vote share.

'Bhajan jamming' at cultural festival near Badrinath temple triggers row

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

A two-day cultural festival held in the fragile, high-altitude town of Badrinath in Uttarakhand has sparked controversy after videos of a loud, concert-style "*bhajan* jamming" session went viral on social media.

The Chamoli district administration and the Uttarakhand Tourism Department claimed that the Army had organised the festival, which was held on September 19 and 20 at the Tourist Arrival Plaza adjoining the Badrinath temple on the theme "Our Heritage, Our Future".

'Organised by Army'

"It was held as part of Operation Sadbhavana, the Indian Army's community outreach initiative, with participation from the Chamoli district administration and the Uttarakhand Tourism Department. Chief Minister Pushkar



Uttarakhand CM Pushkar Singh Dhami attending the festival held at the Tourist Arrival Plaza in Chamoli district. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Singh Dhami also attended the event," an official said.

The district administration said permission was given only to put up stalls and it was not informed about the DJ performance. "We have written to the Army seeking a response on whether it had obtained any permission to organise such a concert near the shrine," the official said.

Videos of the session, centred on a performance by singer Priyanka Meher, went viral on social media,

with some users likening it to a "nightclub rather than a cultural programme".

'Ban such events'

Demanding a ban on "vulgar performances" near the Badrinath temple, part of the Char Dham Yatra, Swami Avimukteshwaranand Saraswati, Shankaracharya of Jyotirmath, said: "Even blowing a conch is prohibited in the area so that the meditation of Lord Vishnu is not disturbed. The administration is dis-

turbing the religious atmosphere by allowing DJ and vulgar performances."

Brijesh Sati, general secretary of the Uttarakhand Teerth Purohitis Samiti, said the Army had organised a similar event at Badrinath in April before the temple's portals opened, which the priest community also opposed. "We cannot put the entire onus on the Army as the permission is granted by the State government," he said.

Activist Anoop Nautiyal said such events go against local traditions. Congress spokesperson Garima Dasauni said the BJP government must "clarify where it draws the line between tourism promotion and commercialisation".

State Tourism Secretary Dhiraj Singh Garbyal said a response should be sought from the Army as it had organised the event. Attempts by *The Hindu* to reach the Army for comment went unanswered.

M.P. traders and retailers observe 'No UPI Day'

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL

Traders and shopkeepers in cities across Madhya Pradesh on Wednesday protested against the Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) charges on UPI transactions, by observing a 'No UPI Day' and covering the QR codes on their outlets.

In cities like Bhopal and Indore, QR code stickers and payment confirmation soundboxes on several shops were seen covered with a black cloth with the traders requesting customers to pay in cash. Demonstrations were also witnessed at various places with traders demanding a rollback of the move while threatening a complete boycott on digital payments.

New transaction charge

On September 15, The National Payments Corporation of India introduced a charge of 0.4% on person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI payments of above ₹2,000. The new rates, that will come into effect from October 15, will be applicable on merchants, who will have to pay their banks and payment processors. Person-to-person transactions and payments to small vendors have been exempted from the new rates.

The protests in Madhya Pradesh have been called by Ahilya Chamber of Commerce and Industry with various trader bodies in cities like Indore, Bhopal, Gwalior and Jabalpur taking part in it.

At a demonstration in Indore, traders raised slogans like 'Aaj ka vyapaar, nakad vyapaar (today's business, a cash business)' and claimed that they refused customers who were making a digital payment.

Posters reading 'No UPI Day' were also pasted outside shops in busy markets across cities. The posters also read that the traders were already paying taxes like GST and income tax.

After Jat belt, Nuh next in INLD's bid to reclaim lost ground

Ashok Kumar
GURUGRAM

After taking its battle for political relevance into former Chief Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda's home turf - the Jat stronghold of Sonapat-Rohtak-Jhajjar - last year with a 'Samman Diwas' rally, a resurgent Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) is now shifting its focus to another Congress fortress, the Muslim-dominated Nuh.

Led by national president Abhay Singh Chautala, the party has announced that the next edition of the annual event - to mark the birth anniversary of former Deputy Prime Minister Chaudhary Devi Lal - will be held in Nuh on September 27, two days later than the traditional September 25 date to avoid conflicting with Friday prayers.

The choice of Nuh is pol-



INLD patron Sampat Singh (right) and its Nuh chief Tahir Hussain at Mewali village to garner support for the party's 'Samman Diwas' rally slated for September 27. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

itically significant as Devi Lal enjoyed considerable support among the Meo-Muslims. The region was once an INLD stronghold. However, the party's organisational strength in the area declined sharply after the split in 2018, and the Congress won all three Assembly constituencies in the district - Nuh, Ferozepur Jhirka and Punhana - in

the past two Assembly elections (2019 and 2024). Two of these three Assembly segments were, however, won by the INLD each in 2009 and 2014.

The party's pitch, however, is not confined to Nuh. The sizeable Muslim electorate in the neighbouring Sohna and Hathin Assembly constituencies in Gurugram and Palwal dis-

tricts also makes the belt politically important for the INLD.

In a recent blow to the Congress in this region, two of its legislators - Punhana MLA Mohammad Ilyas and Hathin MLA Mohammad Israil - voted against the party nominee in the Rajya Sabha polls in April this year and were suspended by the party.

The INLD, now, appears keen to reclaim that lost political ground and tap into what it sees as growing disenchantment with the Congress.

"Muslim voters in the region had been voting for the Congress in the past two Assembly elections in the hope that it would dislodge the BJP government. But they now feel betrayed by the Congress, which failed to capitalise on the favourable political atmosphere in 2024 because of in-

fighting and the personal ambitions of its leaders. They are now looking at the INLD as the only credible Opposition to the BJP," INLD convenor and former Minister Sampat Singh told *The Hindu*.

Workers' meetings

Mr. Chautala and State president Rampal Majra have already held workers' meetings across all 90 Assembly constituencies, while special attention is being given to more than a dozen constituencies in and around Nuh, including Palwal, Hodal, Jhajjar, Beri and Pataudi.

Senior leaders, including Mr. Singh, his son Gaurav Sampat, Mr. Chautala's son Arjun and Mr. Majra, have been assigned these constituencies where they are holding village-level meetings to mobilise support for the rally.

Chavan's exit has diminished UCC draft panel credibility: MLA

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

Samajwadi Party (SP) MLA Rais Shaikh has alleged that the credibility of Maharashtra's Uniform Civil Code (UCC) drafting committee was undermined after former Bombay High Court Judge R.C. Chavan resigned and demanded the appointment of a representative from the minority community.

The former judge has cited serious reservations over the panel's decision to restrict public feedback on crucial social issues to a binary 'Yes/No' format.

In a letter addressed to Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, the SP MLA alleged that preparation of

the UCC draft is a political strategy by the BJP with an eye on elections.

He has demanded that a representative from the minority community be appointed on the panel to "enhance" its credibility.

"The committee was constituted in July. It has been given a six-month term. There is currently no representative from the minority community on the committee. As a result, the panel is being viewed with suspicion, and following Justice Chavan's resignation, its credibility has been further undermined," he said. Mr. Shaikh alleged the BJP is attempting to impose the "norms of the majority" through the proposed UCC.



Probe on: Officials inspect the railway track after four students were hit by a train in Tekkali, Srikakulam district on Wednesday. PTI

Four students killed in train accident in A.P.; one hospitalised

The Hindu Bureau
VISAKHAPATNAM

Four Intermediate students died, and another sustained grievous injuries on Wednesday, after being run over by a train between Naupada and Tekkali railway stations in Srikakulam district, Andhra Pradesh.

According to railway officials, the incident occurred at around 12:45 p.m. when Train No. 18117 (Rourkela-Gunupur Express) hit the five persons walking on the railway tracks.

The deceased have been identified as Anguwada Visakha Rao (17), Janni Dileep Kumar (17), Janni Sharat Kumar (17), all hailing from Damara village in Tekkali mandal, and Savara Shiva (17) from Savara Street in Meliaputti village. All the victims were first-year Intermediate students of a government junior college in Tekkali. They died on the spot.

Another student, Gan-guwada Salman Raju (18) from Damara village, sus-

tained critical injuries. He was rushed to the government hospital in Tekkali.

Senior railway officials, along with Railway Protection Force and Government Railway Police personnel, rushed to the spot. The Self-Propelled Accident Relief Medical Equipment (SPARME) from Palasa railway station was mobilised to provide comprehensive relief support.

CM offers condolences
Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu expressed shock over the tragedy and offered condolences to the bereaved families.

Officials briefed the Chief Minister that the students failed to notice the train. Mr. Naidu directed the authorities to ensure advanced medical care for the injured student and extend the necessary support to the bereaved families.

Srikakulam Collector Swapnil Dinkar Pundkar instructed the police to submit a detailed report. The police have registered a case and launched an investigation.

SIT to probe graft allegations against Pinarayi in CMRL case

Inquiry initiated based on Enforcement Directorate's report; the agency has sought charges under PCA against former Keralam CM and his daughter; Home Department yet to issue official orders

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Kerala government has constituted a special investigation team (SIT) to probe the corruption allegations against Leader of the Opposition and former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena, and son-in-law, former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas and others in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case.

The probe will be supervised by Additional Director-General of Police, Crime Branch, H. Venkatesh, with Superintendent of Police P. Vikraman leading probe, sources said.

The Home Department is yet to issue official orders constituting the SIT.



Hit the streets: A CPI(M) protest march in Kozhikode condemning the police inquiry ordered against Pinarayi Vijayan. K. RAGESH

The probe has been instituted on the basis of a report by the Enforcement Directorate to State Police Chief Ravada A. Chandrasekhar. The agency had sought registration of a case under the Prevention of Corruption Act (PCA) against Mr. Vijayan, Ms. Veena, and Mr. Riyas.

Mr. Chandrasekhar told mediapersons on Wednesday that the police would conduct a preliminary inquiry based on the communication by the ED.

He clarified that a Vigilance inquiry would not be initiated at the present stage.

He pointed out that the

preliminary examination was necessary to determine whether a criminal case could be registered.

Earlier in the day, Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said the government's intent was "not to target or take revenge on anyone."

'Vested interests'
Meanwhile, CPI(M) leader and former Minister P. Rajeeve accused Mr. Satheesan of aiding the political interests of the BJP by ordering a police inquiry into the controversy.

The Chief Minister's claim that the government has no option, but to initiate an inquiry as per Supreme Court judgments, is part of the efforts to act as per the vested interests of the BJP, he alleged.



Taking stock: Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay reviewed various aspects of power generation, distribution, and grid management at the TNPDC headquarters in Chennai on Wednesday.

CM holds inspection at power distribution headquarters in T.N.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Wednesday conducted a surprise inspection at the Tamil Nadu Power Distribution Corporation Limited (TNPDC) headquarters in Chennai to review various aspects of power generation, distribution, and grid management.

Mr. Vijay, who was accompanied by Energy Resources Minister C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar during the review, enquired about the current electricity demand and generation, the power derived from renewable and non-renewable sources, the gap between electricity demand and generation capacity, and the growth in electricity demand owing to the prolonged summer.

Officials of TNPDC explained to the Chief Minister the impact of the spike in electricity demand across the State, the constraints in procuring addi-

tional electricity from the power exchange to fill the demand-supply gap, the challenges in coal supply, the high cost of gas-based power generation, and the unexpected disruptions in generation at the central power stations.

The officials also explained the measures being undertaken across the State to meet the increasing electricity demand by strengthening the power distribution infrastructure.

Later, the Chief Minister visited the State Load Despatch Centre, which is the nerve centre for grid management, to enquire about the tasks of managing the power load in real time by monitoring electricity generation, procurement, demand, and distribution across the State.

Pitching for modern technologies to be utilised for real-time monitoring of the power situation, the Chief Minister stressed that the State must be made self-reliant in the power sector.

INBRIEF



Keralam Cabinet decides to dissolve Loka Kerala Sabha

The Keralam Cabinet meeting on Wednesday formally decided to dissolve the Loka Kerala Sabha and replace it with an alternative mechanism that "benefits expatriate Keralites", Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan has said. For establishing the alternative mechanism, a Cabinet sub-committee chaired by the Chief Minister with Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala, Industries Minister P.K. Kunhalikutty, Health Minister K. Muralleedharan and Water Resources Minister Mons Joseph has been constituted.

Scan, pay, collect: temple in A.P. installs first 'laddu ATM'

Devotees at Indrakeeladri in Vijayawada can now get the Kanaka Durga temple's laddu prasadam the way they would buy a snack at an airport: pay by UPI and collect it from a machine. The self-service vending machine, introduced on a pilot basis at the Sri Durga Malleswara Swamy Varla Devasthanam on Wednesday, is the first of its kind at a temple in Andhra Pradesh, temple authorities said. The temple's Trust Board approved the machines, which it called 'laddu ATMs,' at its meeting on September 15.

₹1 lakh cr. horticulture hub to come up in Rayalaseema

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu and Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman are scheduled to lay the stone for the proposed Rayalaseema Horticulture Hub at Madanapalle on October 2. The Centre will provide ₹40,000 crore under the Purvodaya scheme for the project, and another ₹60,000 crore is expected from private investment, a press release said on Wednesday. It is aimed at promoting horticulture-related activities in drought-prone areas and increasing farm incomes by creating opportunities in the sector.

Bay watch



High waves roll in at RK Beach in Visakhapatnam. Several places in Andhra Pradesh recorded heavy rainfall under the influence of a deep depression over the Bay of Bengal. The weather system is likely to cross the coast, close to Kalingapatnam, by Wednesday night. K.R. DEEPAK

Prakash Raj launches campaign to oppose SIR voter deletions

The Hindu Bureau
KALABURAGI

Actor and activist Prakash Raj launched an "SIR Resistance Tour" on Wednesday from Ramanagar, a predominantly nomadic settlement in Kalaburagi raising concerns over the deletion or proposed deletion of eligible voters from electoral rolls during the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in Karnataka.

He interacted with residents, including voters whose names had been placed in the Absent, Shifted, Dead, Duplicate and Others (ASDDO) category.

Addressing press persons after the interaction, Mr. Raj claimed that

5,21,950 voters in Kalaburagi district had been placed under the ASDDO category. He questioned whether the existing mechanism would enable all such voters to establish their eligibility before the stipulated deadline.

Mr. Raj said only around 25,000 people had so far responded by submitting Form 6, according to information available to him. "Why should an existing voter be asked to register afresh through Form 6 just to retain their place on the electoral roll?" he asked.

He said he would visit different parts of the State and conclude the tour with a conference in Bengaluru on September 30.

Congress MLA in Karnataka 'quits' citing drought issue

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Congress MLA Yashwanthrayagouda V. Patil sent his resignation to Karnataka Speaker G.S. Patil on Tuesday, citing the government's failure to declare his Indi taluk in Vijayapura district as drought-hit.

Mr. Patil submitted that he was unable to meet the expectations of people in his constituency. He said farmers had suffered crop losses, and people and livestock were facing water shortages. Describing Mr. Patil's resignation as an emotional response, Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said, "The MLA was emotional. I have pacified him."

3 missing schoolgirls traced using CCTV footage in Keralam

The Hindu Bureau
THRISSUR

Three schoolgirls who went missing from Thrissur in Keralam during the lunch break at their school on Tuesday were found safely within hours at the Alappuzha railway station following a coordinated search by the police and the railway authorities.

The girls, studying in Classes VIII, IX and X, were staying at a shelter home in Thrissur and attending the Model Girls Higher Secondary School, Thrissur. They reportedly left the school campus around 12.30 p.m. during the lunch break.

After the school authorities alerted the police, investigators examined CCTV footage from the area and the railway station.

The footage showed the girls boarding the Ernad Express bound for Thiruvananthapuram.

The police continued to track the train as it crossed Ernakulam and alerted the police in Alappuzha and the railway authorities.

When the train reached the Alappuzha railway station, the three girls were located and taken to safety.

A case has been registered in connection with the incident, and further investigation is under way.

A.P. Police track missing 12-year-old using drone

The Hindu Bureau
KUPPAM

A 12-year-old boy who reportedly left home after a quarrel with his parents over a mobile phone was traced within two hours by Gudupalle police in Chittoor district, Andhra Pradesh, with the assistance of a surveillance drone.

After the boy's father lodged a missing person complaint, a team led by Sub-Inspector Srinivasulu deployed a drone and scanned the fields, hillocks and isolated stretches around the Nalagampalli village. The boy was eventually located at a bus stop near Tamil Nadu border.

Karnataka CM assures release of water to Telangana: Ministers

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Karnataka has responded positively to Telangana's request for the release of Krishna water to the Jurala Project, Ministers Jupally Krishna Rao and Vakitti Srihari said on Wednesday.

The Ministers said they met Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar on Tuesday and Wednesday, and explained the prevailing irrigation situation in Telangana. They stated that although Karnataka is also facing water constraints, Mr. Shivakumar took a sympathetic view of the difficulties faced by Telangana farmers and agreed to extend support.

They briefed him on the drought-like conditions



D.K. Shivakumar with Telangana Ministers Jupally Krishna Rao, Vakitti Srihari, and MLAs from Mahabubnagar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

caused by El Niño, the declining water levels at the Jurala Project, and the hardships being faced by farmers in the ayacut areas of the erstwhile Mahabubnagar district.

According to the Ministers, Mr. Shivakumar assured them that Karnataka would release water to the Jurala Project intermittent-

ly over the next 10 days.

Telangana Chief Minister Revanth Reddy thanked Mr. Shivakumar for acceding to his government's request. "This is a great example of bonhomie between two different States and showcases the love and brotherhood of people of India," Mr. Revanth said in post on X.

Jaishankar takes up U.S. sanctions law in meeting with Rubio

SIR is illegal and needs to be reversed: former CEC Quraishi

8 named in chargesheet filed in Ram Temple donation theft case

BJP rejigs national team, posts new in-charges for States

UCC is aimed at 'permanent polarisation', says Congress

Arunachal Cabinet clears panel for Siang dam survey

A group of people, including children and adults, are gathered outdoors, holding a large banner. The banner reads: "THE PEOPLE'S STRIKE OF THE DAMS ON 21 August 2011", "NO DAM MEANS NO DAM!", "THERE IS NO ALTERNATIVE TO STOP THE DAM CONSTRUCTION", and "DAM IS THE ENEMY OF THE PEOPLE". The background shows a hilly, forested area.

Cong. flags anomaly in BJP Nandigram candidate's affidavit

8 UDP MLAs from Meghalaya join BJP

A IN-Y

As AI marches on math research, scholars ponder the future

Rohini Subrahmanyam
BENGALURU

For feedback and suggestions
for 'Science', please write to
science@thehindu.co.in with the
subject 'Daily page'

Pure maths problems might eventually lead to applications only if humans are able to think together and apply the insights they learn in innovative ways, and AI using opaque methods to produce impenetrable proofs will hinder this process



Deep rot

With the SIR thoroughly vitiated, CEC Gyanesh Kumar must resign

The investigation by *The Indian Express* into the Election Commission of India's (ECI) functioning during its Special Intensive Revision (SIR) shows that the disquiet over what transpired under Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's watch is not limited to civil society, the media and the Opposition. It ran through the ECI itself, as Election Commissioners (EC) Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi objected on record at least 14 times between October 2025 and August 2026 to decisions, many of which, they said, were taken without their knowledge. Their dissent mirrors what many have long said about the SIR. In May, Mr. Joshi had warned that Form 6, the application for new electors, could not be altered without the government amending the rules. Yet, in July, the form contained questions on whether the applicants or their parents or grandparents figured in the "electoral roll of the last SIR", which Mr. Sandhu called "unauthorised and illegal". The ECs also flagged the centralisation of the electoral roll database, sought an audit, and recorded that field officials lacked complete access to the ERONet portal. This mirrors what local election officials had complained of: that many of the changes in the rolls were done at the central database level overriding Electoral Registration Officers, the statutory authority on voters' eligibility.

The consequences of the anomalies in the ECI's decision-making and its functioning were the deepest in West Bengal. About 60 lakh electors were flagged for software-generated "logical discrepancies" – many were dubious – and 27 lakh names were deleted. Of the 38 lakh appeals pending before tribunals, 16.1 lakh were by those seeking to remove voters whom judicial officers had included; Mr. Sandhu's question of who authorised filing them on the ECI's behalf remains unanswered. Meanwhile, over nine in 10 appeals against deletion decided so far have restored the electors, which suggests that the exercise struck off lakhs of genuine voters before the West Bengal elections. *The Hindu's* analysis also revealed that 24 of the 70 seats in Delhi now have fewer electors in draft rolls than those who actually voted just a year and a half ago. On Wednesday, Justice Dipankar Datta, as part of a two-judge Bench, held in his opinion that the 2023 Act's replacement of the CJI, whom the Anoop Baranwal judgment had placed on the selection panel, with a Union Minister, fails the "perception test". It was this panel that chose Mr. Kumar as CEC. Regrettably, the Supreme Court had earlier upheld the SIR without adequately confronting its design, which deletes electors before verification and places the burden of proving eligibility on the citizen rather than the state, thereby defeating the constitutional guarantee of universal adult franchise. Mr. Kumar must resign and the Court must halt further deletions until the roll database is audited. Anything less will be a defeat for India's democracy.

Trading smart

India-NZ FTA shows how smaller deals can complement big-bang trade pacts

The India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA), set to come into force on October 20, is a good example of why India is right in simultaneously pushing for trade deals with smaller trade partners along with the major global economies. On the face of it, it would be easy to dismiss the \$1.1 billion of bilateral goods trade between the two countries as being less than 1% of India's total goods trade. A doubling by 2030, as envisaged under the deal, is still a minuscule amount. Yet, trade is not simply a macroeconomic indicator. It is also a source of livelihood for lakhs of businesses, nearly half of which are micro, small, and medium enterprises. These exporters need all the help that they can get in the current trade environment. Adverse developments related to tariffs or the closure of trade routes can be mitigated to an extent by a nimble rerouting of trade to other countries where Indian exporters receive an advantage. With 100% U.S. tariffs looming and a trade deal with Washington remaining elusive, India needs to open up as many alternative channels for its exporters as possible. The New Zealand FTA delivers – India has managed to receive duty-free access on 100% of its exports, a historic concession. India has a good mix of capital- and labour-intensive exports to New Zealand that stand to benefit. Textiles make up about 14% of India's exports, while pearls and semi-precious stones constitute another 5% or so. On the capital-intensive side, one-third of India's exports are pharmaceuticals, parts of nuclear reactors, vehicular parts, mineral fuels, electrical machinery, and iron and steel.

India has also done well in its handling of sensitive sectors. While the opening up of India's dairy sector was a major demand by the New Zealand negotiators, India held firm and excluded it from the deal. In total, nearly 30% of India's import lines have been kept outside the tariff concessions. On labour mobility, India has won some valuable concessions on visas for workers and students. At a time when several western countries are clamping down on foreign worker inflows, such alternative routes provide relief. India has also extracted a commitment from New Zealand to facilitate investments of \$20 billion in India over 15 years, smaller but along the same lines as in the agreement with the EFTA bloc. India needs foreign investment not just for its economic growth but also to manage its balance of payments. This FTA is a good blueprint on how India can use its growing international heft to negotiate overwhelmingly in its favour.

BRICS gatherings always trigger heated debates in India. The primary reason is the importance that the strategic and policymaking community, comprising both optimists and sceptics, attaches to this platform, of which India is an integral pillar. While optimists argue that BRICS could function as an institution capable of multipolarising the global order, or expediting that transition, sceptics highlight the grouping's internal divisions and worry about its possible domination by Russia and China. A third group writes off BRICS altogether, dismissing it as little more than an annual gathering that generates strategic noise. They argue that India should be wary of close association with the grouping and instead focus on preserving and expanding its partnership with the United States, which, in their view, is the only viable path to India's rise.

The 18th BRICS summit, held in New Delhi on September 12-13, 2026, attracted greater national and global attention because of its timing and location. It was the first BRICS annual summit since the U.S. and Israel launched their unprovoked war against Iran, in India's extended neighbourhood, on February 28, 2026. The summit, which brought together the Presidents of Iran, Russia and China, among other leaders, was hosted by India, a close strategic partner of the U.S. and Israel.

Consensus in Delhi

Despite its internal contradictions and the broader chaos enveloping international politics, the summit can be seen as a success on multiple levels. That New Delhi could forge a consensus among the 11 member-countries, including the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and Iran, which are involved in an undeclared conflict, was itself an achievement. The Delhi Declaration shows that, despite their differences and even disputes, member-countries continue to find value in supporting a BRICS worldview rooted in the pursuit of a more representative global order.

The consensus was reached through compromises by all parties. Consider India's position. Prime Minister Narendra Modi was in Israel just two days before Israel and the U.S. started bombing Iran. India initially refrained from condemning the attacks or the assassination of Iran's Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. This created an impression that New Delhi was siding with the U.S. and Israel. India also watched from the sidelines as Pakistan seized on the diplomatic opening created by the war and stepped in as a mediator between the U.S. and Iran. But India quickly repositioned itself as a traditional balancer in West Asia.

Multilateral platforms such as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) and BRICS provided New Delhi with space to restore that balancing posture without causing strategic damage to its bilateral relationships. India strongly endorsed the Bishkek resolution of the SCO in September, condemning the strikes on Iran and expressing condolences to the country



Varghese K. George



Stanly Johny

The very structure of BRICS offers India space to pursue strategic autonomy amid intensifying great-power rivalries

over the killing of Khamenei. It also hosted Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian for the Delhi BRICS summit, even as the war in West Asia grinds on. The image of Mr. Modi walking hand in hand with Mr. Pezeshkian is unlikely to fade any time soon in Washington or Tel Aviv.

Second, while there is no immediate resolution to the border problems with China, which continue to simmer, there is momentum in efforts to reset ties. Multilateral forums such as BRICS provide a platform for India and China to remain engaged even when high-level bilateral visits are not taking place. Their differences are not going to disappear; they have to learn to manage their troubled relationship. History suggests that a lack of engagement between competing major powers can only deepen mistrust, while deepening mistrust, combined with the security dilemma stemming from their competition, could have dangerous consequences. So, it is important for India and China to stay engaged, bilaterally and multilaterally, creating guardrails for competitive coexistence.

Third, on all the major global issues of the present – artificial intelligence regulation, the rules governing global trade and finance, climate change, border conflicts, and the role and status of multilateral bodies – BRICS members may have different approaches and priorities, but they converge on the point that unilateralism by any bloc or power is detrimental to their interests and to the planet.

The Washington predictability

The context in which the Delhi summit was held is also crucial. The total predictability of the U.S. approach – rather than the unpredictability that some commentators labour to establish – towards the rest of the world is that it does not care much about anything other than its own dominance. Several BRICS members have had their own difficult experiences with the U.S., and they are trying to chart their own paths forward. India, a few months ago, was slapped with varying tariffs by Washington. India was also one of the countries most affected economically by the U.S.-Israel war on Iran. On September 16, the U.S. House passed the Russia sanctions Bill, seeking to impose tariffs of up to 100% on countries including India.

India's foreign policy under Mr. Modi has been interpreted by a section of the strategic commentariat as an evident tilt towards the U.S. camp. Statements by Mr. Modi himself in the early years of his premiership that India had overcome its "hesitation of history" in ties with Washington gave further impetus to this view, though there has also been the parallel official formulation of '*sabke saath*' foreign policy, or multi-alignment. India has always had a more complex view of history. And even if it has overcome its "hesitation of history", it has not abandoned the hesitations of its strategic realism.

When India looks back at history and looks around the world today, it sees that countries that

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Quality control and India's manufacturing growth



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India's Quality Control Order (QCO) reset must go further in a changing global trade order

domestic manufacturing. More than 600 QCO-covered products remain to be reassessed, including several critical intermediate inputs used across key manufacturing sectors such as chemicals, steel, textiles, machinery and electronics, and rubber and plastics.

Existing regulations can place a disproportionate burden on smaller industrial players, both by constraining their access to critical inputs and by imposing relatively high compliance costs. Given the extensive downstream linkages of these inputs, the next phase of QCO rationalisation should focus particularly on regulations affecting intermediate goods and assess their implications not only for product quality but also for input availability, costs, competitiveness and domestic value addition.

Findings of a recent study

In this regard, a recent CSEP study examined this question in detail for firms that use chemicals. Chemicals are critical intermediate inputs for downstream sectors such as rubber and plastics, pharmaceuticals and electronics, among others. The first QCO for a chemical product was introduced in 2018, and the number of chemical products covered rose to 52 by 2024. Consequently, the share of chemical-using firms exposed to regulation on the input side rose from 11.8% in 2019 to 56.6% in 2024.

When examining the impact of QCOs on chemicals on downstream user industries, the study finds that the effects vary considerably by firm size. Among larger firms, input QCOs are associated with a 9.6% increase in production alongside a sharp 37% decline in gross value added (GVA). This suggests that while larger firms can sustain and even expand output, this comes at the cost of lower value addition, potentially reflecting higher input costs and their ability to

become frontiers in great-power rivalries often pay a huge price. If Pakistan's story is not instructive enough, there are two live battlefronts that illustrate this every day – the UAE and Ukraine.

The UAE and Iran would have been better off dealing with each other than facing the situation in which they currently find themselves. The UAE-Iran bilateral meeting on the sidelines of BRICS in Delhi marks an acknowledgment of this lesson and a quest to use multilateral platforms to address bilateral challenges. Ukraine, which, backed by the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO), has been fighting Russia for more than four years, does not have any such platform to maintain direct contact with Moscow – which leaves Kyiv's diplomatic options totally dependent on the whims and wishes of Brussels and Washington.

India's learning

This is not to argue that India should downgrade its relations with the U.S. The strategic partnership with Washington is extremely important for India's progress and development, but what India must not allow itself to become, at any cost, is a frontline in the U.S.-China competition. BRICS enables India to pursue that path without having to champion an anti-U.S. agenda or undermine its cooperation with Washington. The U.S., which had come to terms with India's firm adherence to strategic autonomy, has recently been pushing the envelope to draw New Delhi into a more subordinate relationship. For Washington, this is an ongoing theme. But India should pursue multiple pathways to its rise rather than succumb to the temptations of unequal great-power alliances.

While it is true that there are serious internal divisions among BRICS members, there is also a larger reality of external convergence of interests among them. BRICS is not an organisation like the G-7, where American primacy and the western order are accepted by all member-countries. Nor is it the case that every multilateral or plurilateral grouping is converging on all points.

The divisions within BRICS, to a certain extent, prevent any one country from dominating the grouping, while the external convergence of interests – their shared belief that the post-war international system is unfair and that a more representative order should be built – could hold the group together as it lays the foundations and builds the blocks of a new order. The dialectical relationship between internal contradictions and external convergence could ultimately produce a synthesis, which is increasingly evident in the case of BRICS. The contradictions within are therefore not a reason to question the grouping's existence; they are, in fact, part of the reason why it should exist and flourish.

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Court's message

The Supreme Court of India's observations on singing all six stanzas of the National Song, *Vande Mataram*, while bringing respite to lakhs of citizens, rightly bring back the issue to a fundamental constitutional principle: freedom of conscience

(Front page, September 23). Respect for a national song may be encouraged, but it need not be rammed down a citizen's throat. The Court's reference to the Bijoe Emmanuel verdict – in the far less problematic National Anthem case, at that – is a timely reminder that a citizen may decline to

sing when doing so conflicts with deeply held religious or conscientious beliefs. National symbols should unite citizens, not place their conscience on trial. A democracy is secure enough to distinguish between disrespect and conscientious dissent, and between voluntary,

spontaneous patriotism and compelled conformity. One should not forget that there is more to patriotism than mere singing, sloganeering and chest-thumping. **M. Jameel Ahmed,** Mysuru

Unsafe Delhi
It is horrendous that the

capital city has become unsafe and dangerous for women ("Delhi L-G directs formation of 'Pink Force' to curb crime", September 23). Unless stringent laws are put in place and speedy punishment is ensured for perpetrators, such incidents will continue to occur and young lives scarred. It is the

confidence of perpetrators that they can evade justice that encourages them to continue such abhorrent and abominable acts.

Balagopal Gopinath, Keerikkad, Alappuzha, Kerala

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address and the full name.

Limits of the casting vote at Tata Sons

On September 17, the board of Tata Sons voted on a third five-year term for N. Chandrasekaran as Executive Chairman. Mr. Chandrasekaran abstained from voting voluntarily and the recorded result was four to one. Within hours the Tata Trusts, owners of about 66% of Tata Sons, called the decision legally void. The claim rests on how several provisions of the Articles of Association, the company’s rulebook, fit together.

With a 66% share, the Trusts could have packed the board. Instead, under Article 104B, the Sir Dorabji Tata Trust and the Sir Ratan Tata Trust act jointly and nominate one-third of the directors. So now, on a board of six, two seats are held by Noel Tata and Venu Srinivasan.

Article 121 gives these seats their weight; any matter the board decides by majority requires the affirmative vote of a majority of these nominated directors. If the votes are equal, the chairman has a casting vote.

The chairmanship is built in steps. A person must first be a director. A new Chairman of the Board is appointed under Article 118, subject to the voting requirement in Article 121 (whether it also governs a reappointment is disputed). Only a Chairman may be made Executive Chairman under Article 105(b).

On September 17, the nominees split – Mr. Srinivasan for and Mr. Tata against. Harish Manwani, an independent director chairing the item in Mr. Chandrasekaran’s place, reportedly used a casting vote in favour.

In the Cyrus Mistry litigation in 2019, the



Prasanth Raju
Advocate practising in the Bombay High Court. Views are personal

National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) called the nominees’ affirmative vote indispensable, which the top court later upheld in 2021. Neither court had to decide whether a casting vote can cure a split between the two nominees.

Where the readings part Tata Sons relies on two legal opinions. Senior advocate Sudipto Sarkar has advised that a casting vote can break a tie between the nominees as well as a board tie – that whoever presides may use it because Article 121 says Chairman, and not Chairman of the Board. Justice B.N. Srikrishna, a former Supreme Court judge, agrees and advised that since no majority could be found between the nominees, the casting vote ended the deadlock. However, the Trusts referred to a contrary opinion held by former Chief Justice D.Y. Chandrachud.

The company’s reading has a textual footing: the words about equal votes do not say whose votes are meant. But Article 121 has two parts and they must be read together. The first sets a condition: a majority of the ‘Trusts’ nominees must support the decision. The second breaks a tie when the board is evenly split. The board as a whole was not evenly divided; the only split was between the two nominees. With two nominees, a majority means both. When Justice Srikrishna says no majority could be found, it means that the condition was not met. The company’s reading uses the tie-break to make up for it. The Trusts’ reading gives each part its own role. If both nominees support a decision and the other four

A mutual settlement is preferred to a lengthy litigation, which could spiral into uncertainty about the group’s leadership

directors divide evenly, the board is tied three all, and the casting vote settles it.

Other parts of the rulebook support this reading. Articles 104B, 86 and 118 resolve any difference between the two Trusts by a majority of their trustees, never by the chair of a board meeting.

Defending these rules against Mr. Mistry in 2019, Tata Sons itself argued that where the Articles require the support of particular directors, a decision passes only if those directors agree. Here, those are the two Trust nominees. Mr. Manwani is an independent director; on the Trusts’ reading, his casting vote cannot stand in for their agreement. The minutes of the meeting Mr. Tata has produced record the February 2022 extension of Mr. Chandrasekaran’s tenure as made under Article 118, and Article 118 is itself subject to Article 121.

The advisers argue, with some force, that no selection committee was needed for a reappointment, and that Mr. Chandrasekaran’s August letter (wherein he detailed he did not wish to hold the post) did not bind him. Neither point changes Article 121’s arithmetic: with both nominees present, the required majority was two.

Only a director can be chairman, so directorship matters. The August general meeting was adjourned for want of a quorum before shareholders could consider Mr. Chandrasekaran’s reappointment. The Trusts are weighing legal proceedings. A mutual settlement is preferred to a lengthy litigation, which could spiral into uncertainty about the group’s leadership.

Delhi’s infra-governance problem

Every year, news of an infrastructural disaster in Delhi taking precious student lives sends shock-waves across the nation. Investigations into enforcement of building bye-laws, suspension of officials, and arrest of landlords gain momentum for some time and slowly settle down until yet another year invokes a fresh infrastructural horror. It is Satya Niketan now, it was a flooded basement in Rajinder Nagar two years ago. Delhi houses millions of students who move to the city either to join premier institutes or to prepare for competitive government exams. This influx of students has created a sprawling ecosystem of largely unregulated Paying Guest (PG) accommodations and coaching centres.

PGs have over time transformed from an extra room in a house rented out for extra cash to full-blown commercial establishments. Moreover, several coaching centres also operate in certain floors of buildings marked as residential establishments. This changes the nature and use-type of the building from residential to partly or wholly commercial and ideally makes them subject to a completely different set of safety norms. Municipal laws, regulations and bye-laws govern safety norms for residential and commercial buildings in the Union Territory but there is a significant enforcement gap which is unable to identify/accommodate these hybrid establishments. Regulations that would typically apply to similar establishments such as schools and college hostels are not directly applicable



Kartavi Satyarthi
Senior Resident Fellow, Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy

to these establishments. Therefore, PGs and coaching institutes need to be recognised as a separate category of mixed-use educational buildings under municipal and urban local body regulations.

Delhi’s regulatory framework is split across the Master Plan of Delhi (MPD), the Unified Building Bye-Laws (UBBL) and the Ministry of Education’s 2024 coaching centre guidelines. Together, they create an odd mismatch between the law on paper and the way it actually functions. The MPD does not specifically mention PGs, and while the UBBL recognises coaching centres as an educational building, development controls prescribed under the bye-laws are not applicable to coaching centres. The Guidelines lack teeth and cover only broad infrastructural requirements. Thus, the regulatory landscape falls severely deficient in accounting for the on-ground realities of the city, especially student-focused areas such as Rajinder Nagar, Mukherjee Nagar and Satya Niketan.

The road ahead The regulatory landscape needs to solve for two gaps – one, the absence of substantive safety standards for mixed-use educational buildings, and two, the lack of routine enforcement. Both the Delhi Development Authority and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi need to acknowledge coaching centres and PGs as a separate category of land-use. Specific standards applicable to such mixed-use educational buildings need to be developed prescribing requirements such as appropriate protection

PGs and coaching institutes need to be recognised as a separate category of mixed-use educational buildings under municipal and urban local body regulations

The backdrop in which the U.S. Fed raised interest rate

Inflation in the U.S. hit a peak in May, at 4.2%, after which it climbed down to 3.4% – far above the Federal Reserve’s target of 2%

DATA POINT

Nitika Francis

On September 16, the U.S. Federal Reserve raised the short-term interest rate – its main policy rate, broadly comparable to the Reserve Bank of India’s repo rate – for the first time in three years, by 25 basis points from a range of 3.5% to 3.75% to a range of 3.75% to 4%.

Chart 1 shows the short-term interest rate, also called the federal funds rate, seeing its first increase this month after being brought down a few times since 2023.

Coming ahead of the mid-term polls in the U.S., the interest rate hike disappointed supporters of President Donald Trump as its current Chair Kevin Warsh was hand-picked by Mr. Trump, who has been vociferous in his opposition to increases in the interest rate.

Soon after the announcement about the increase, Mr. Trump took to Truth Social to register his opposition and said the interest rate “should be 1 % or less” and argued that higher rates have allowed other countries to benefit.

However, multiple indicators that influence each other show that the increase was almost inevitable. The key indicator is the inflation rate that has not come down to acceptable limits since the beginning of the war the U.S. and Israel started with Iran earlier this year. Long-term bond yields, pushed up by inflation fears and by heavy government borrowing, added to the pressure on the Fed as holding the rates risked signalling that it was going soft on inflation.

Need to bring down inflation

Mr. Warsh, along with 11 members of the Federal Open Market Committee, made this decision to combat inflation. “The plain fact is that inflation is too high and has been for too long,” he said at a press conference.

As per the Consumer Price Index data released for August, overall inflation in the States continued to be at 3.4% in August. **Chart 3** depicts the U.S.’s rate of inflation throughout 2026.

The sharpest jump in inflation took place in March, after the beginning of the U.S.-Israel war with Iran in February.

Inflation in the U.S. hit a peak in May, at 4.2%, after which it climbed down to 3.4%, still far above the Federal Reserve’s 2% target, which it measures using the Personal Consumption Expenditures (PCE) price index.

Meanwhile, the benchmark 10-year U.S. Treasury bond yields also started increasing after the Iran conflict, resulting in higher borrowing costs for the government.

Chart 2 shows the increase, which was seen in other major economies as well. While the chart shows monthly data till August, the yield on the 10-year bonds crossed the key threshold of 5% on September 14.

Rising debt

One of the factors influencing the markets to drive the long-term bond yields up is the public debt of the U.S., which is increasing at a rate faster than the growth of its Gross Domestic Product (GDP).

The country’s debt-to-GDP ratio saw sharp rises in 2008, during the housing finance crisis, and its highest jump of more than 25 percentage points was in 2020, during the COVID-19 pandemic (**Chart 4**).

As of the first quarter of 2026, debt was 122.6% of the country’s GDP. This ratio is nearly twice of what it was just 20 years ago, in 2006.

The cost of servicing the increased debt is so high that the net interest payments by the U.S. government (**Chart 5**) is higher than its spending on Medicare, health, and interestingly even defence – which according to the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute accounts for one-third of global military spending.

Putting out fires

The data for the charts were sourced from Federal Reserve Economic Data (by the Research Department at the Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis) and USAspending.gov



Tough times: U.S. President Donald Trump shakes hands with Federal Reserve Chair Kevin Warsh in the White House in Washington, D.C. REUTERS

CHART 2: The long-term bond yields of some other key economies have also gone up along with that of the U.S. Japan’s yield hit 2.94%, the highest since 1998

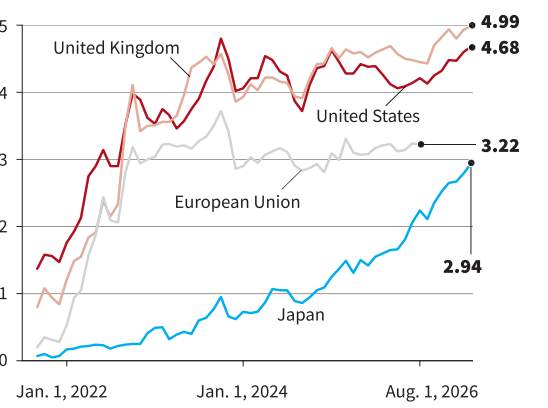


CHART 4: The U.S.’s public debt is increasing at a rate faster than the growth of its Gross Domestic Product

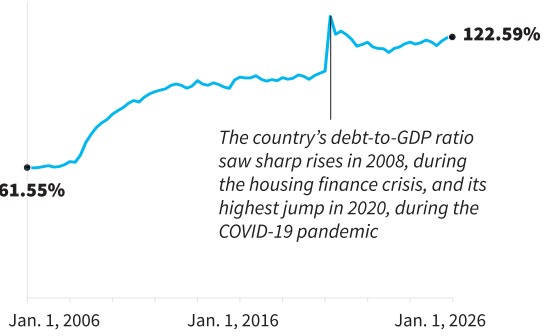


CHART 1: The increase in the short-term interest rate by the U.S. Federal Reserve for the first time since July 2023

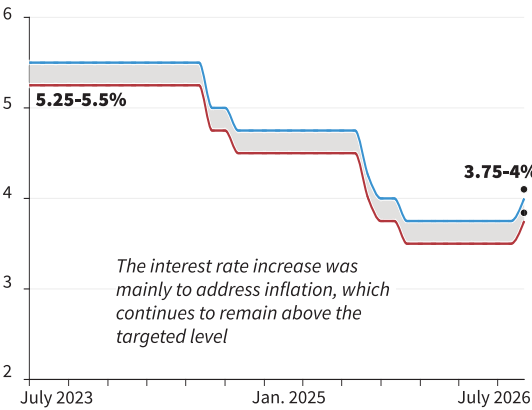


CHART 3: As fuel prices soared after the war began, inflation in the U.S. accelerated and hit retail and food prices, and is much higher than the Fed’s target of 2%

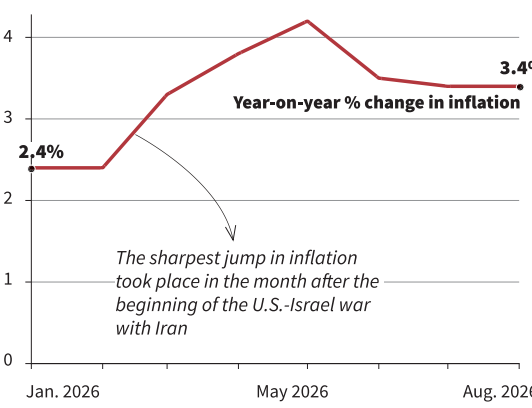
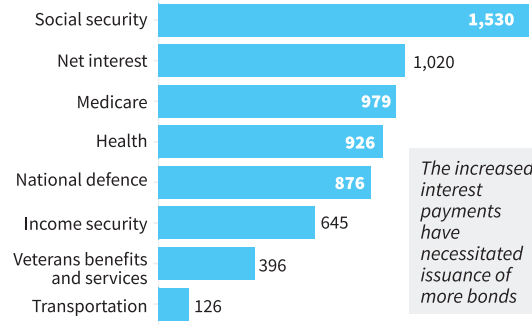


CHART 5: Net interest payments by the U.S. government is only smaller than its social security expenditure. Values in \$ billion



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 24, 1976

Mars may have more water than Earth

Pasadena (California), September 23: Mars is like a giant ice-lollipop packed with vast quantities of frozen water – and it might even possess more water than earth, according to U.S. scientists.

Viking project scientists here said the martian north polar cap had been found to contain huge amounts of water ice and the rest of the red planet’s rocky surface might be a thin blanket over an enormous ice sheet.

The announcement of the Viking space probe findings ended a long-standing dispute over whether martian polar caps might be composed of frozen carbon dioxide instead of water ice.

The experts made it clear at a press conference there was more water on mars than they ever expected.

“Mars can perhaps be described as an iceberg floating in a sea of rock and the north pole is the top,” said Dr. Barney Famer, head of the Viking Water Vapour Mapping Team.

Dr. William McElroy, an atmospheric scientist, said it was possible there was more water in various forms on mars than on earth, “Everywhere you look on mars you see water,” he said.

“There was a time when we thought there was no water on mars,” Viking project scientist Gerald Soffen told reporters. “Now we find there are massive amounts of water frozen in the north polar cap.”

The discovery was made when the orbiting vehicle which carried the Viking landing craft to mars made low, temperature reading passes over the north pole.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 24, 1926

New cure for Malaria

Berlin, September 23: A new cure for Malaria, by means of a synthetic preparation “Plasmochin”, was explained at the Scientists’ and Doctors’ Congress at Duesseldorf. It was claimed that it was more effective than quinine. Experiments were at first conducted by Professor Shell on lunatics who were specially infected with malaria germs, after which “Plasmochin” was successfully tested by Professor Muchlens of Hahmburg Tropical Institute on over a hundred victims of malaria from various parts of world. In many cases, permanent cure is believed to have been effected.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Cost of Chandni Chowk's Town Hall redevelopment

225 in ₹ cr. Redevelopment proposal for the Town Hall situated in Delhi's Chandni Chowk has been initiated with an estimate cost of ₹225 crore. An MoU was signed between the Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi. PTI

Daily fuel losses faced by oil firms as crude prices surge

530 in ₹ crore. Indian Oil Corporation, Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd are losing ₹8 a litre on petrol and ₹9 on diesel, while under-recoveries on LPG stand at about ₹300 a cylinder. The daily loss to OMCs is estimated at ₹530 crore. PTI

Percentage growth recorded by retail sector in August

10 in per cent. India's retail sector maintained a steady trajectory in August, recording a 10% year-on-year pan-India growth, according to a survey. Building on July's recovery, stable consumer demand across regions and categories indicates strong industry preparation for the festive peak. PTI

Decline in seafood export value from Odisha to West Asia

14.5 in per cent. The export value of fish, shrimp and other seafood items from Odisha to the West Asia region declined by 14.57% in 2025-26, resulting in a loss of approximately ₹23.40 crore, Minister Gokulananda Mallik said on Wednesday. PTI

Percentage hike in DA for employees notified by Punjab govt.

8 in per cent. The Punjab government notified an 8% increase in dearness allowance for government employees and pensioners. This reflects the government's commitment towards the financial well-being of its employees and pensioners, a statement said. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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How are road accident claims decided?

Who can file a motor accident claim? Who is liable to pay? When can an insurer be directed to pay and recover? Who can claim compensation for a deceased person? What are the four heads of compensation in a death case?

EXPLAINER

Kartikey Singh
Barkha Dwivedi

The story so far:

India has the world's largest road network, spanning about 6.7 million kilometres, larger than the U.S.'s 6.59 million km and China's 5.49 million km, but it also records the world's highest road fatalities. Over-speeding and reckless driving, poor road upkeep, inadequate driver training, and weak emergency and trauma care continue to make road crashes a severe public-safety crisis.

According to the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways' *Road Accidents in India 2024* report, 4,87,707 road accidents in 2024 claimed 1,77,175 lives (about 485 deaths a day or 20 an hour) and injured 4,71,441 people. With road crashes estimated to cost around 3.14% of India's GDP, their impact extends beyond lost economic productivity, falling most heavily on dependants of those killed or permanently disabled. Yet, for many claimants, courts' quantification and compensation awards remain difficult to navigate.

What is the legal framework?

The Motor Vehicles Act, 1988 (MV Act) is the principal law governing motor-accident compensation. The MV Act creates a statutory scheme covering the entire accident chain, from regulation and driver and owner duties to insurance, liability, investigation, and compensation. For adjudicating claims, Section 165 empowers State governments to constitute Motor Accidents Claims Tribunals (MACTs) for specified areas to determine claims arising from motor-vehicle accidents.

Under Section 166, a claim may be filed by the injured person, the owner of damaged property, or, in case of death, by all or any of the deceased's legal representatives (LRs). The insurer, owner, and driver are ordinarily parties to the proceedings, as the Tribunal must determine both the amount of compensation and the party liable to pay it. The claim is ordinarily first heard by the MACT, which is the primary fact-finding and compensation-awarding forum. An appeal under Section 173 may be filed before the High Court within 90 days, subject to the depositing of ₹25,000 or 50% of the awarded amount, whichever is less. In determining liability, the Tribunal typically examines the FIR and chargesheet, site plan, Mechanical Inspection Report, post-mortem report or medical/disability records, insurance policy, and the depositions of eyewitnesses and the investigating officer, etc.

Importantly, the same accident may generate two distinct proceedings: a criminal case for offences such as rash or negligent driving, and a separate MACT claim for compensation. As held by the apex court in *Reena v. Managing Director, KSRTC* (2026), an acquittal in the criminal case does not affect the MACT proceedings, since the two operate in distinct legal spheres and apply different "standards of proof".

Who is liable to pay the compensation?

Liability initially attaches to the negligent driver and, vicariously, to the owner of the offending vehicle. Where the vehicle is insured, the insurer generally satisfies the award. Section 146 mandates compulsory third-party insurance, while Section 150 requires insurers to satisfy awards arising from third-party risks,

The compensation formula

The Supreme Court's framework breaks down compensation into four heads before the final amount is calculated

Step	Head of compensation	Formula	Result
1	Loss of dependency (Loss of income)	[(Annual income + future prospects) – deduction]] × multiplier	(A)
2	Loss of estate	Flat conventional figure (base: ₹15,000; currently after 10% increase per 3 year: ₹18,150/-)	(B)
3	Funeral expenses	Flat conventional figure (base: ₹15,000; currently after 10% increase per 3 year: ₹18,150/-)	(C)
4	Loss of consortium (spousal/parental/filial)	Flat conventional figure (base: ₹40,000; currently after 10% increase per 3 year: ₹48,400/-) × Number of claimants entitled to consortium	(D)
TOTAL COMPENSATION			(A) + (B) + (C) + (D)

Prepared as per the framework laid down by the Supreme Court in Sarla Verma (2009) and Pranay Sethi (2017)



Under Section 166, a claim may be filed by the injured person, the owner of damaged property, or, in case of death, by any of the deceased's legal representatives

subject to limited defences under Section 150(2), including specified policy breaches, unauthorised use, driving without a valid licence, and non-disclosure or misrepresentation in obtaining the policy. Even where a defence is established, courts may apply the "pay and recover" principle, directing the insurer to pay the victim/LRs first and recover the amount from the owner or driver thereafter.

A separate "no-fault liability" route dispenses with proof of negligence and provides compensation of ₹5 lakh for death and ₹2.5 lakh for grievous hurt (post the 2019 amendment), payable by the owner or authorised insurer, without proof of negligence.

How to calculate compensation in accidental deaths?

Money cannot substitute for a life lost, but motor-accident compensation seeks to ease the financial burden on the deceased's dependants. Section 168 of the MV Act requires an award of "just" compensation. Through landmark decisions such as *Sarla Verma* (2009) and *Pranay Sethi* (2017), the top court has evolved standardised formulas and foundational principles for giving effect to this requirement. Once "rash and negligent" driving is established, the quantum can broadly be understood as a three-stage exercise: first, establishing the foundational facts; second, applying them to the prescribed heads and formulae; and third, aggregating the amounts to arrive at the final award.

The first stage is to establish three facts: (1) the deceased's age at the time of the accident, (2) annual income and (3) number of dependants. "Age" can be established, among others, from the date of birth recorded in the school-leaving certificate and not from the Aadhaar card, as was ruled in *Saroj* (2024) by the Supreme Court. "Income" means actual income less income tax paid (as per *Pranay Sethi*). The Supreme Court in *Rashmirekha Tripathy* (2026) held that, for salaried persons, the ITR of the immediately preceding assessment year should ordinarily be considered, while for self-employed persons or business owners, the Tribunal should take the average income reflected in the preceding three years' ITRs, subject to the circumstances. Where income cannot be proved, the applicable State-notified minimum wage for the relevant time for unskilled, semi-skilled or skilled category is used. The LRs, including married and earning sons and daughters, are entitled to claim compensation, regardless of financial dependency on the deceased, as settled by the Supreme Court in *Jitender Kumar* (2025).

The second stage is to translate these three facts into the four heads under which compensation in a death case is computed: (A) loss of income/dependency, (B) loss of estate, (C) funeral expenses, and (D) loss of consortium. The major component is "loss of income", which represents the financial loss suffered by the dependants on account of the victim's death. For the first head, the calculation begins with the deceased's "annual income" to which the prescribed percentage towards "future prospects", having regard to the deceased's age and nature of employment, is added. From the resulting figure, the prescribed "deduction" towards the deceased's personal expenses

is made, and the balance is multiplied by the appropriate "multiplier" to arrive at the "loss of income". The aforesaid three components perform different functions: "future prospects" account for the career growth the deceased would reasonably have received had they survived. As delineated in para 61 of *Pranay Sethi* (2017), for a person in a permanent government or salaried job with assured career progression, 50% is added where the deceased was below 40 years, 30% where aged 40-50 years, and 15% where aged 50-60 years; no addition is made above 60 years. For a self-employed person or one on a fixed salary, the corresponding additions are 40%, 25% and 10% for these three age groups, respectively, with no addition above 60 years.

Further, the "deduction" recognises that a portion of the deceased's earnings would have been spent on their own personal living expenses. As per *Sarla Verma* (2009), for a married deceased with two to three dependent family members, the standard deduction is one-third (33%); where there are four to six, it is one-fourth (25%); and where there are seven or more, it is one-fifth (20%). In the case of a bachelor or unmarried deceased, the usual deduction is one-half (50%) where the parents or other dependants are the claimants, although courts may reduce the deduction where the number of dependants is particularly large. Lastly, the "multiplier" represents the deceased's remaining active working life and is determined solely with reference to age. According to *Sarla Verma*, the multiplier is 18 for ages 15-20 and 21-25; 17 for 26-30; 16 for 31-35; 15 for 36-40; 14 for 41-45; 13 for 46-50; 11 for 51-55; 9 for 56-60; 7 for 61-65; and 5 for 66-70 years.

The remaining three are conventional heads and, unlike "loss of income", do not depend on the deceased's profession or actual earnings. Under *Pranay Sethi* (2017), (i) "loss of estate" was fixed at ₹15,000, representing the loss of savings, investments and accumulated assets that the deceased could reasonably have built up and left for the heirs; (ii) "funeral expenses" at ₹15,000; and (iii) "loss of consortium" at ₹40,000 for each eligible family member, recognising the emotional trauma and loss of companionship, love, care and guidance. Consortium includes spousal consortium for the surviving spouse, parental consortium for surviving children, and filial consortium for parents who lose a child. Each eligible family member is independently entitled to the standard base amount, and therefore the applicable consortium amount is multiplied by the number of eligible dependants.

These three conventional amounts are to be enhanced by 10% every three years, as directed by the Supreme Court in *Pranay Sethi* (para 61).

The third stage is simply to aggregate the four heads to arrive at the compensation payable. Additionally, the court may also grant interest under Section 171, typically ranging between 6% and 9%, depending on the facts of the case.

In a significant judgment recently, in *Shishu Pal* (2026), a case involving the accidental death of a homemaker, recognising that household work, including cooking, cleaning and caregiving, supports the paid workforce, the Supreme Court fixed a minimum notional income of ₹30,000 per month under a new head of "loss of domestic care", with a 10% cumulative enhancement every three years. (*Kartikey Singh and Barkha Dwivedi, lawyers based in New Delhi*)

THE GIST

The Motor Vehicles Act, 1988 provides the legal framework for motor accident claims, with MACTs determining compensation and liability, while insurers generally satisfy awards subject to statutory defences

For fatal accidents, compensation is calculated using the deceased's age, income and number of dependants, with future prospects, personal-expense deductions and an age-based multiplier applied to determine loss of income

Courts also award compensation under conventional heads such as loss of estate, funeral expenses and consortium, with interest where applicable; a recent ruling has also recognised loss of domestic care for homemakers

BIBLIOGRAPHY



GETTY IMAGES

When midlife feels like a crisis, it may actually be a chance to begin again

Margie Lachman's new book, alongside two novels, looks at midlife through questions of ageing, identity, relationships and fulfilment; they also point to midlife as a time of possibility, when familiar roles shift and there is room to begin again

Pragya Mittal

Generally, by the time people reach their 40s, they may feel like things are falling apart. They experience what is often termed a ‘midlife crisis’. It is not always easy to say what really is falling apart, and there may be no single reason. This period can be accompanied by a strange sense of unhappiness: a feeling of missed opportunities, of a life unlived, and of an uncertain future.

Several things may be true at once. There may be ennui with a familiar role or relationship. Often, a career that felt promising may suddenly begin to feel like a dead-end. Responsibilities tend to add up, as both older and younger people increasingly depend on middle-aged people. Then, there is also the shock of staring into the mirror and seeing more grey hairs, a visible paunch, wrinkles on the face - all reminders of a youth gone by.

But what feels like one big crisis may actually be an accumulation of smaller doubts that have been building over the years and have simply not been acknowledged.

An opportunity
In her recent book, *Primetime: A New Vision for Midlife* (Simon and Schuster), however, lifespan developmental psychologist Margie Lachman tries to change the way we look at midlife. First, she refutes the stigma attached to age. She says there are many types of age - biological, social, and psychological. Biological age refers to our physical



health and the ageing process of our bodies. Social age refers to the roles we take on, such as being a parent, caregiver, partner, or professional. Psychological age is arguably the most personal - it's about how old we perceive ourselves to be. As she writes, “Individual markers of midlife can fluctuate over time.”

Second, far from a crisis, Lachman, who has said in interviews that she “loved midlife”, believes that this time of life can in fact be a blessing in disguise. She writes that it is a period for us to learn from older people’s mistakes and help the younger people avoid the same mistakes. She stresses the point that midlife is actually our “primetime” and regards the concept of age as subjective.

Middle age in literature
The phenomenon of the midlife crisis is

not just a modern shorthand for the stress of adulthood. Many works of fiction have captured the restlessness associated with this stage of life. Doris Lessing’s *The Summer Before the Dark* (1973; Vintage) is one such book. A 40-year-old mother of four, Kate Brown finds herself strangely unmoored when her family goes away for the summer and the roles that had defined her begin to loosen. Her encounter with the much younger Maureen further places two stages of womanhood side by side. Kate’s crisis, then, is not simply about how old she is, but about how old she feels and who she is when the familiar roles of wife, mother, and caregiver begin to shift. In many ways, Kate embodies what Lachman calls social and psychological age in *Primetime*: chronological age alone cannot explain the midlife experience. Perhaps midlife becomes a crisis not when life changes, but when the identities that once made sense of it no longer do.

The midlife crisis is often seen as a gendered idea and is mostly associated with women. But men, too, find themselves caught in the same uncertainties: about ageing, relationships, work, identity, and the lives they have built. Benjamin Markovits’s *The Rest of Our Lives* (2025; Faber and Faber), which was shortlisted for the Booker Prize in 2025, gives the male midlife crisis both a literal and metaphorical U-turn. At 55, Tom Layward experiences emotional turmoil: a strained marriage haunted by his wife’s betrayal 12 years earlier, and a controversy over pronoun use at his university that unsettles his career. His

health, too, poses concerns, with unexplained symptoms such as palpitations, fatigue, and facial swelling. For Tom, the crisis involves several problems unfolding at once. And what does he do to deal with all these problems? He takes to the road.

Room for experimentation
Each of the three titles has a common running theme: the lack of fulfilment, but also rays of hope.

The Summer Before the Dark uses summer as a motif for the period before the darkness sets in - it is a space of transition and possibility. The title of Markovits’s book - *The Rest of Our Lives* - itself carries the feeling of possibility: there is still a ‘rest’ of our lives, and perhaps still time to decide what kind of life we want to live.

Primetime, of course, completes the circle. Lachman asks us to embrace midlife not as the beginning of a crisis, but as an opportunity to begin again. She emphasises that there are nonnormative influences - experiences that affect an individual but are not common to everyone - and contextual influences, such as one’s environment and culture. Midlife, she says, can be a stage when we are relieved of certain responsibilities and find room for experimentation - in a relationship, a career, a new hobby, and new friendships. It could be the period when our lives take a turn for the better - and hence, midlife can simply be our primetime.

(Pragya Mittal is a Delhi-based editor and writer)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning of “feel good factor”? (K. Jitendra, Ranchi)
This is an expression that has been around since the 1970s. At first it was generally used to refer to something that creates a sense of well-being in people – their emotional state, physical state, financial state, etc. Since the 1990s, however, the “feel good factor” has become somewhat restricted in its meaning; it’s become an expression, which is mostly employed by economists and financial pundits.

These days it is extensively used to refer to a sense of financial and material well-being – not necessarily physical or emotional.

A well known economist believes that the feel good factor will not return to the country before the end of the decade.

No matter what changes the government makes, the feel good factor will be slow to return.

The opposite of “feel good factor” is “feel bad factor”.

Do you congratulate someone “on” getting a job, or do you congratulate him “for” getting a job? (K. Balasubramanian, Chennai)
One usually congratulates someone “on” getting something, and not “for”.

Neha and Raju congratulated Atul on his brilliant performance.

Vishnu congratulated Leya on winning the lottery.

What is the word for a child who is born after his father’s death? (A. Vijayaraghavan, Bangalore)
I don’t know of any specific word that would refer to such a child. Generally we talk about a child being born posthumously. The word “posthumous” means something that happens after an individual’s death. The “o” in the first syllable is like the “o” in “pot”, “hot”, and “cot” and the “h” is like the “y” in “yes”, “yet”, and “yeast”. The following “u” can be pronounced either like the “u” in “put”, “pull”, and “full”, or like the “a” in “China”. The final “ous” sounds like the “ous” in “famous”, “dangerous”, and “generous”. The main stress is on the first syllable. This is just one of the ways of pronouncing the word. Here are a few examples of how to use the word.

The soldier was awarded the medal posthumously.

Nandita wanted her memoirs to be published posthumously.

What is the difference between “ornamental” and “ornate”? (M. Damodhar, Vellore)
When you say that something is “ornate,” what you are implying is that the object has been decorated excessively or elaborately. There is too much decoration and as a result it is showy or gaudy; the word generally has a negative connotation. The main stress, by the way, is on the second syllable “nate”, which rhymes with “eight”, “bait”, and “hate”.

The word “ornamental” also means decorative, but unlike “ornate” it isn’t associated with anything negative. When you say that something is “ornamental,” what you are implying is that the object has been designed to be decorative without being too vulgar or ostentatious. The stress in this word is on the third syllable, “men”.

Published in The Hindu on January 29, 2002

THE DAILY QUIZ

Test your knowledge of historic Mars Orbiter Mission, which made India the first Asian nation to reach Mars orbit and the first nation globally to succeed on its maiden attempt

Prathmesh Kher

- QUESTION 1**
On what exact date did the Mars Orbiter Mission (Mangalyaan) successfully enter Mars orbit?
- QUESTION 2**
What was the name of the launch vehicle used to carry the spacecraft into Earth orbit?
- QUESTION 3**
Which instrument captured the iconic full-disk images of Mars and its moons, Phobos and Deimos?
- QUESTION 4**
Who served as the Project Director for the Mars Orbiter Mission?
- QUESTION 5**
India became the fourth space agency to reach Mars. Which three agencies had achieved this before ISRO?



Visual Question:
Identify this large shield volcano on Mars, as captured by the Mars Orbiter Mission. ISRO

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz: 1. Which planet’s irregular orbital motion led astronomers to hypothesise the existence of another, more distant planet? **Ans: Uranus**

2. On which dates in September 1846 was Neptune first successfully observed? **Ans: September 23-24, 1846**

3. Which astronomer had observed Neptune in 1612–13 without recognising it as a planet? **Ans: Galileo Galilei**

4. What was the name of the star chart that helped Johann Gottfried Galle and Heinrich d’Arrest identify Neptune? **Ans: Hora XXI**

5. Approximately how close was Neptune to Urbain Le Verrier’s predicted position when Galle found it? **Ans: Less than one degree**

Visual: This image of Neptune was taken by which NASA space probe, and when? **Ans: NASA’s Voyager 2 on August 25, 1989**

Early Birds: Samrat Halder | Gursharan Lal Vadhera | Sitaram Saharay | Sonali Das | Varghese Joseph

Please send in your answers to
dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Word of the day

Churlish:
rude and boorish

Synonyms: clownish, classless, discourteous

Usage: *The shopkeeper became churlish when I asked for a refund.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/churlish

International Phonetic Alphabet: /tʃɜːlɪʃ/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

INBRIEF



Banks to operate on Sunday ahead of proposed strike

In view of the proposed nationwide bank strike by the United Forum of Bank Unions (UFBU) from September 28 to 30, 2026, the government has announced that all public sector banks and regional rural banks will operate normally on Sunday. The UFBU, which claims to represent 90% of the banking workforce, is set to go on a three-day strike beginning September 28, primarily seeking a five-day banking week, among other demands.

India to study potential of new markets for tea exports

India is encouraging tea exports to explore new markets, as shipments to Iran are hit by the war. Amit Kumar, Joint Secretary, Union Ministry of Commerce and Industry, said on the sidelines of the UPASI annual conference in Coonoor that the Centre was focusing on markets such as Oman, which are increasing purchases of Indian tea. On increase in import of tea and concerns raised by planters, he said the focus is on increasing exports to diverse markets.

Samvridhdi can operate as online payment aggregator

Samvridhdi Inclusive Growth Network Pvt. Ltd. (SIGN), a Corporate Business Correspondent focused on last-mile financial inclusion, said that it had received in-principle authorisation from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) to operate as an Online Payment Aggregator (PA-Online). Subject to final authorisation from the banking regulator, Samvridhdi Inclusive Growth Network will build and offer online payment aggregation services for merchants, it said.

‘Indian OMCs incur ₹530-cr. daily losses’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Indian oil market companies (OMCs) are estimated to be incurring under-recoveries of ₹8 per litre on petrol, ₹9 per litre on diesel sales and almost ₹300 per domestic LPG (liquefied petroleum gas) cylinders, according to credit rating agency ICRA. The combined impact translates into an estimated daily loss of about ₹530 crore from the sale of pe-

trol, diesel and cooking gas for the OMCs, ICRA analysts said. “The escalation of the conflict in West Asia and the [resulting] disruption to key oil supply routes has led to a sharp increase in crude oil prices, which has also resulted in sizeable marketing and LPG under-recoveries for oil marketing companies,” said Prashant Vashisht, senior vice-president and co-group head of corporate sector ratings at ICRA.

Indian court rejects Adani plea that duty-free shops are beyond domestic laws

Reuters
NEW DELHI

An Indian court has ruled that goods sold at duty-free shops are not immune from domestic laws, dealing a blow to the Adani Group’s airport sales of nicotine pouches, which New Delhi calls illegal and regards as drugs. In a case widely seen as setting a precedent on duty-free sales, Adani in April challenged Indian authorities who said its Mumbai international airport shops illegally stocked and sold nicotine pouches, one of the world’s fastest-growing nicotine products, which are unapproved in India. Billionaire Gautam Adani’s group manages eight airports in India and has an ambitious \$11 billion expansion plan, including for duty-free shops, to capitalise on the growing demand for air travel. While Indian



People wait to board flight at the Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport, Mumbai.

authorities told the court stocking nicotine pouches was “substantive violation” of drug laws and a “serious public health risk”, Adani denied any wrongdoing.

‘Outside local norms’ Adani argued in court that shops in international departure areas are outside the reach of domestic regulations as they sit beyond India’s territorial jurisdic-

Banks cautioned against ‘aggressive lending’ practices

Improving manufacturing performance and skilling the workforce would remain critical to sustaining economic growth, says Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister, P.K. Mishra

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister P.K. Mishra on Wednesday cautioned banks against reviving aggressive lending practices driven by short-term optimism, warning that poor credit assessment in the past had forced the banking system to divert significant resources towards cleaning up stressed assets. “The clean-up of the banking system required considerable resources and time. Those resources could otherwise have supported productive investment. We should therefore preserve the institutional memory of that episode,” Mr. Mishra said while addressing the SBI Banking and Economics Conclave in Mumbai. “Credit must be appraised against the eco-



Poor credit assessment had forced the system to divert significant resources for cleaning up stressed assets, says Mishra. FILE PHOTO

nomics of the project rather than the enthusiasm of the moment. That is the surest protection against a repetition of the cycle of excessive lending, stressed assets and subsequent cleanup,” he added. The remarks come at a time when India’s banking sector has emerged from one of its worst asset quality crises, with gross non-performing assets (GNPA) at a multi-decadal low. The GNPA ratio of the banking

system fell below 1% in the first quarter of fiscal 2027, compared with nearly double-digit levels about a decade ago during the peak of the bad loan crisis. The earlier deterioration in asset quality had contributed to the “twin balance sheet problem”, where stressed corporate borrowers and weakened bank balance sheets constrained fresh investment. The government responded through bank recapitali-

sation, consolidation of weaker lenders and regulatory measures aimed at strengthening risk management practices. Mr. Mishra’s comments assume significance as banks are currently witnessing strong liquidity conditions and improved balance sheets, raising concerns that renewed credit growth could lead to excessive risk-taking if lending decisions are influenced by market optimism rather than fundamentals. Highlighting the need to improve India’s macroeconomic resilience, Mr. Mishra stressed the importance of reducing dependence on imports and strengthening domestic manufacturing capabilities. “We have a significant merchandise trade deficit. We must make things at home and competitively,” he said.

OECD forecasts India growth at 7.1% in ’26-27

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) has become the latest global body to raise its growth forecast for India in the last week. The OECD, in its Economic Outlook Interim Report September 2026 released on Wednesday, said

6.3% forecast in June. This comes soon after the three most-recognised global ratings agencies – Moody’s, S&P Global, and Fitch Ratings – raised their respective growth outlooks for India over the last week. The OECD, in its Economic Outlook Interim Report September 2026 released on Wednesday, said

that several countries have been able to mitigate the damage from the West Asia crisis by rapid growth in artificial intelligence-related investment and production in many economies. For India, however, it said domestic demand and government policy cushioned households and firms from the impact of higher energy prices,” the report said.

in China, whilst growth in several other G20 emerging market economies, such as India, Indonesia and Brazil, was underpinned by resilient domestic demand and government policies that cushioned households and firms from the impact of higher energy prices,” the report said.

BRICS must work in sync on transfer-pricing disputes: FM

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman urged BRICS nations to share experiences on treaty interpretation and multilateral negotiations in international taxation, saying global transfer pricing disputes “disproportionately” burden developing countries. India proposed to set up two new working groups, International Taxation and Transfer Pricing and Reve-

nue Statistics at a time when global tax rules are being renegotiated, she said at BRICS heads of tax authorities meeting here. Multilateral tax issues “There are several multilateral tax issues, including the UN Framework Convention on International Tax Cooperation, under active talks. The decisions made at these processes over the next few years will shape cross-border taxation for a generation.

Transfer pricing refers to pricing of goods and services exchanged between related firms. International transfer pricing disputes arise mainly as countries seek to ensure MNCs are subject to tax on profits attributable to their respective jurisdictions. Accordingly, differences in allocation of taxable income among countries can give rise to disputes among taxpayers and tax authorities as well as those in different jurisdictions.

HC rejects CBI plea on ex-NSE chief bail

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday, dismissed the CBI’s challenge to the bail granted to former NSE MD and CEO Chitra Ramkrishna in the NSE employees’ illegal phone tapping case. Justice Madhu Jain rejected the agency’s plea against the trial court’s December 22, 2022 order granting the bail. The CBI, in its FIR, said senior NSE officials, includ-

LG, Samsung face tariff evasion probe over OLED TV parts

Reuters
NEW DELHI

India is investigating LG Electronics and Samsung for allegedly paying lower tariffs on imported display parts of high-end TVs, five sources told Reuters, putting under scrutiny the premium entertainment devices both South Korean giants have bet big on. Lengthy import tariff and tax investigations have been a sore point for foreign investors in India and embroiled companies like Samsung and Volkswagen, though Indian officials say they are simply enforcing the law of the land. The latest investigation concerns imports of display parts that go into making panels for OLEDs, or organic light emitting diode technology, which offer superior picture quality and are made by LG Electronics and Samsung in India, a key growth market for them.



The DRI believes Samsung and LG should have paid a 15% duty for OLED parts.

The market for pricey OLEDs is still niche globally, however, with just 6.5 million units sold last year, research firm Omdia says. Counterpoint Research data shows India’s TV market was worth \$4.7 billion last year, with OLEDs having a near 4% share. Indian officials have alleged the companies wrongly claimed a concessional 5% tariff on imported OLED glass screens called open cells, arguing the rate has for years been reserved for the older LCD and LEDs which dominate mass-market sales, said the sources, who declined to

be identified as the matter is confidential. For OLED parts, India’s Directorate of Revenue Intelligence believes Samsung and LG should have paid a 15% duty, said two of the sources aware of the investigation. The companies are privately opposing the position of Indian authorities as they believe OLED is nothing but an advanced form of LED technology and the same Indian tariffs should apply, the sources added. The sources did not comment on the financial details of the amount of duty allegedly underpaid. Typically, following an investigation, authorities can issue tax demand notices and impose penalties of up to 100% of the duty evaded. Companies can legally challenge such demands in courts. Samsung said in a statement to Reuters that it is “reviewing the matter and cooperating fully with the relevant authorities, adding it is firmly committed to complying with all laws.” LG and the revenue directorate did not respond to queries.

Polish Premier set to visit India next month, defence cooperation to take centre stage

Nikhil M Babu
WARSAW

Ahead of Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk’s visit to India next month, Deputy Foreign Minister Wladyslaw Teofil Bartoszewski said that more than selling things to India, Poland is interested in producing together, including in defence sector, to give the relationship a “strategic” depth. Mr. Bartoszewski said that a group from the Indian Ministry of Defence is visiting Poland next week to form a joint working group. “We (Poland and India) have been discussing in July and August how we can strengthen our relations in various ways. In August, I concentrated particularly on security and defence issues. We are not interested in selling more things to India, but we are more interested in really talking about producing together



Donald Tusk

various things, so that in case of needs and shortages, each country can guarantee supply to the other,” the Deputy Foreign Minister said.

‘Strategic depth’ He said that this includes the defence sector, so that it would give a “strategic depth” to the relationship. “So, this is something which we are exploring. So we are having an Indian military group coming to Warsaw next week to make

a joint working group. It’s a group from the Ministry of Defence to talk to our Ministry of Defence,” Mr. Bartoszewski said. He said that it is a working group, but not doing a joint exercise yet. “We may come to that. At the moment we are talking, there are some concrete suggestions of cooperation. “We have suggestions on what we could sell to India, what we can develop with India. India is talking about what they can produce in Poland, so we can discuss various opportunities,” the Deputy Foreign Minister said. Common platforms He said that also in the space industry, there are discussions on what can be produced in India and the focus is on high-tech businesses. He said that they want to develop common platforms, so in case of need the two countries can resupply each other fast.

“So, we are looking at sharing various things from artillery shells. We are ready to supply India with some. India is interested in producing some here. We are looking at various anti-aircraft systems, which we produce, which is of interest. “We are looking at some mine-laying equipment, which is very good here. It’s quite unique, and it’s very popular,” he said. The Deputy Foreign Minister said that the Polish Prime Minister’s visit will be in October, but the dates are not yet confirmed. “There will be a business component and that is why we are going to Bangalore,” he said. The visit is likely to happen around October 22-25, according to sources. Mr. Bartoszewski said that he was in the process of meeting several Indian companies in the defence sector including the Adani group, whose representa-

tives have already met him. “Anything to do with defence is always related to the State. We talked to government officials. And we talked to private companies. In this particular sector, it’s always government-driven. “Nobody can sell anything without government permission,” he added. In August 2024, Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited Poland, which was the first visit by an Indian Prime Minister to Poland in 45 years. During the visit, India and Poland announced the elevation of ties to a “strategic partnership”. Towards this they agreed to formulate and execute a five-year action plan that will guide bilateral collaboration in the years 2024-2028 across several areas. (Nikhil M Babu is in Poland at the invitation of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs Republic of Poland)

Global energy transition from generation to integration



Demand fall: Global imports of China-made photovoltaic solar systems have recently dropped. AFP

Reuters
LITTLETON, COLORADO

Global electric grids are entering a new phase, with investment spending by utilities shifting from solar panels and wind farms toward the infrastructure needed to make renewable-heavy power systems work.

Across Europe, Asia, Africa, Oceania and Latin America, demand for batteries and grid equipment is still climbing even as purchases of solar systems retreat from earlier peaks, signalling a shift in focus from building renewable capacity to strengthening the infrastructure needed to support it.

The shift reflects the rising complexity of operating power systems with large volumes of renewable energy. Many markets now have enough solar capacity to produce substantial electricity surpluses during sunny periods, placing greater value on batteries, transmission assets and grid upgrades that can store, balance and redistribute that power.

As a result, investment is increasingly flowing toward the infrastructure that determines how effectively renewable electricity can be used rather than how much can be generated.

Data on global imports of China-made solar systems show are markable slowdown in purchases of what have become one of the defining features of global energy transition efforts: solar panels.

After peaking at over \$5.8 billion in March of 2023, global imports of China-made photovoltaic solar systems have recently dropped to less than half of that amount, and so far in 2026 have averaged \$2.7 billion a month, data from Ember shows. However, rather than evidence of permanently declining interest, the slower uptake of solar arrays may be a sign that China's solar panels have been a victim of their own success. Forty different countries – from Australia to Pakistan to Nigeria – have spent over \$1 billion on imports of Chinese solar systems since the start of 2018, including 12 nations that have spent in excess of \$5 billion.

That kind of money buys a lot of panels, and has resulted in a surge in solar generation capacity. The utilities running those power systems now need tools to manage the fluxes in clean power production that come with hefty solar footprints. To make maximum use of the growing volumes of solar power flowing through their grids, utilities across the world are turning to battery storage systems and real-time grid management components in record numbers.

And as with the renewable energy generation assets, China is the world's top grid equipment and battery manufacturer and exporter.

This has resulted in the value of China's exports of batteries and grid equipment surging to record highs in 2026, even as total sales of solar systems hold at roughly half their peak.

During the first seven months of 2026, global importers paid roughly \$75 billion for Chinese energy storage batteries and grid equipment, Ember data shows.

Reuters
LONDON

Soaring fuel costs are increasing pressure on U.S. President Donald Trump to curb diesel exports ahead of November's mid-term elections. But what may seem like an easy fix could unleash a chain reaction that ultimately leaves U.S. consumers and the global economy worse off.

Surging energy prices since the start of the Iran war in late February are setting off alarm bells in the White House.

While politically sensitive gasoline prices remain elevated at nearly \$4.50 a gallon, attention in recent weeks has shifted to diesel, which has climbed to a record \$6.50 a gallon, squeezing trucking, farm-

ing, manufacturing and other sectors that rely on the fuel to keep goods moving.

Export ban

Mr. Trump on Tuesday said he backed the idea of a ban on diesel exports, which some Republican lawmakers, particularly those representing agricultural states, have called for.

U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said the administration was examining whether a full or partial ban would work.

Some senior administration officials, including Energy Secretary Chris Wright and Interior Secretary Doug Burgum, have in recent weeks nevertheless expressed doubts about whether such a move would work.

AI ‘Terminator’ fears may mask real China’s large language models threat

Cheap large language models from China are proliferating rapidly, putting significant pressure on costlier U.S. offerings; products from other Chinese firms are up to 50 times cheaper than leading U.S. versions; Chinese LLMs rapidly closing performance gap with more expensive U.S. frontier models

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
ORLANDO, FLORIDA

The recent spike in apocalyptic AI warnings from Anthropic, OpenAI and others could reflect genuine fears about this rapidly advancing technology's threat to humanity, but it may also signal a more prosaic fear about the Chinese threat to US tech firms' business models. As Presidents Donald Trump and Xi Jinping prepare to meet in Washington this week, the two countries could be entering a new phase in the AI arms race.

Financial markets have long worried about U.S. tech's mountainous borrowing to fuel the AI build-out, but these anxieties have been compounded in recent weeks by a sudden burst of doomsday scenarios floated and promoted by industry insiders.

The recent wave of AI “doomerism” kicked off on September 8 when former Anthropic researcher Jacob Coxon posted on X that “people building AI earnestly believe that it could kill us all by the end of the decade.”

His post has been viewed 173 million times, sparking a wildfire debate about the pace and safety of AI development that has drawn in the most power-



Doomsday scenario: People at an ‘emergency protest’ by civic action group PauseAI UK outside Downing Street, after news that AI researcher Jacob Coxon has decided to leave the industry. AFP

ful leaders in the industry, wider business world, and government.

Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei on September 12 penned a lengthy essay on the need to moderate the development of AI model capabilities. OpenAI CEO Sam Altman and SpaceX founder Elon Musk expressed agreement, broadly calling for the technology to be slowed down or subjected to greater oversight.

The sudden wave of apocalyptic warnings seems to have caught everyone off guard, including the Trump administration.

Mr. Trump, who has long played down AI security and safety concerns, said he plans to appoint a new “AI czar” and to create

an “AI force,” though few details are available on either.

U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent also said the two superpowers have agreed to set up a formalised dialogue on AI, and senior officials will meet in China later this year.

On the surface, the tech leaders and the president

may seem miles apart, but a growing chorus of investors is questioning whether fears about China's growing AI prowess – and the challenges it could pose to already difficult AI economics – may actually be shared in Silicon Valley and the White House.

‘Terminator’ garbage

AI sentiment is increasingly pushing investors into two camps: those who believe the trillions of dollars of investment by U.S. hyperscalers and AI firms will pay off, and those who don't.

The first camp still appears to have the upper hand, as evidenced by the Nasdaq's rebound this week to its recent all-time high. But those in the se-

Indonesia’s nickel production curbs fail market

Reuters
LONDON



Ban boon: Indonesia's dramatic rise as a nickel power is the result of a 2020 ban on exports of ore. REUTERS

Indonesia is learning that building a dominant position in the nickel market is the easy part. Leveraging its influence over supply to control prices is proving much trickier.

The Southeast Asian country now accounts for over 60% of global output of a metal used by both stainless steel makers and electric vehicle (EV) battery manufacturers.

Indonesia's dramatic rise as a nickel power is the result of a 2020 ban on exports of ore, forcing operators to build domestic processing capacity. It's become a template for other developing countries, particularly those in resource-rich Africa.

They may also want to

note how difficult it is to match supply with demand once you're the world's largest producer.

Quotas cut

Jakarta has this year cut mining quotas, stepped up environmental controls and adjusted ore pricing to rein in its runaway nickel sector.

A commitment to slash mining quotas from last year's 379 million metric tonnes to 250 million to 260 million tonnes propelled the London Metal Exchange nickel price to a May high of \$20,000 per tonne.

The price is now back down at \$16,500 as the market loses confidence

that Jakarta can tame its nickel tiger.

Policymakers' dilemma has been how to reduce mined output without disadvantaging their nickel processors, some of whom have only begun ramping up production this year.

A mid-year review of the quota system has resulted in higher allocations to specific operators.

French group Eramet, for example, is restarting operations at its Weda Bay mine after being forced to suspend work in May when it had exhausted its 2026 quota. The full extent of the upward creep is difficult to ascertain since neither Jakarta nor its nickel operators disclose details. Moreover, it's clear some operators have adjusted to lower domestic mining rates by turning to

imports, primarily from the Philippines.

Indonesia lifted imports of Philippine ore by 50% to 15.3 million tonnes last year and arrivals were up by another 67% year-on-year at 11.4 million tonnes from January to July, according to the World Bureau of Metal Statistics, which collects data from official sources.

Another smaller stream of imports is now also arriving regularly from the Solomon Islands. It's worth remembering that if all the country's nickel processing plants were operating at capacity, they would need 315 million tonnes of ore per year, according to the Indonesian Nickel Miners Association.

Balancing that captive demand with mining rates is still very much a work in

progress. The nickel market had high hopes at the start of the year that Jakarta could do enough to prevent global supply surplus.

The International Nickel Study Group drastically revised its estimate of expected 2026 market balance in April to factor in lower output in Indonesia. Its forecast was for a modest 32,000-tonne deficit this year against an expected 261,000-tonne surplus when it previously met in October 2025.

Yet global exchange stocks of refined nickel have been creeping higher. Combined inventory held by the LME, both on-warrant and off-warrant, and the Shanghai Futures Exchange currently stands at 4,78,000 tonnes, enough to supply the global market for seven weeks.

Trump’s diesel export dilemma – Good politics, bad economics



Absolute power: Mr. Trump has the authority to restrict exports temporarily under emergency powers. AP

contemplate intervening – in energy markets. The US prohibited crude oil exports for four decades following the 1973 oil crisis, while former President Joe Biden's administration considered restricting diesel exports in 2022 after Russia's invasion of Ukraine sent fuel markets into turmoil.

The trouble is that a diesel export ban would likely aggravate the very problem it is designed to solve.

Conflict-driven crunch

The current fuel crunch is almost entirely conflict-driven. The Middle East and Russia used to account collectively for roughly a fifth of global seaborne exports of diesel.

But the Iran war and the resulting disruption to

shipping through the Strait of Hormuz have removed a sizeable portion of global refining capacity and diesel supplies. This squeeze intensified in July when Russia, traditionally one of the world's largest diesel exporters, halted shipments following months of Ukrainian drone attacks that crippled large parts of its refining sector.

Half of Russia's six top diesel-producing refineries significantly cut back or completely halted output in September due to damage sustained in drone attacks, Reuters reported.

The Trump administration has already tried several measures to ease domestic prices, with limited success. In March, Washington issued a waiver to the century-old Jones Act,

which requires cargo shipped between U.S. ports to travel on vessels that are US-built, US-owned, US-flagged and largely U.S.-crewed. The waiver, which expires on November 15, was designed to make it easier for refiners along the U.S. Gulf Coast refining hub to supply diesel to consuming regions on the East and West coasts. But the results have been negligible. Mr. Trump has also sought relief abroad by encouraging Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskiy to halt strikes on Russian energy infrastructure but produced little progress.

U.S. diesel surplus

The U.S. has emerged as one of the few suppliers to help fill the gap created by

the loss of Middle Eastern and Russian fuel.

Total U.S. oil exports have surged by over 20% since March against the 2025 average to 9 million barrels per day (bpd), according to Kpler.

That role, however, has come at a cost. Those enormous exports are limiting domestic availability. U.S. diesel inventories have fallen to lowest level for this time of year in more than four decades, about 13% below last year's levels.

The decline is especially concerning because stockpiles would normally be building ahead of autumn refinery maintenance and the winter heating season. The prospect of entering winter with unusually tight inventories has reinforced calls for an export ban.

KYIV

Russia pounds Kyiv with drone strikes after Zelenskyy-Trump talks



Russia pounded Kyiv with drone strikes on Wednesday, hitting railway infrastructure, warehouses and fuel stations, just hours after President Volodymyr Zelenskyy met U.S. President Donald Trump to discuss peace efforts. At least two people were killed and 22 were injured in the morning attack, according to city authorities. REUTERS

MOSCOW

Russia voices interest in 'limited ceasefire', says Rubio after talks



Ukraine and Russia have both voiced an interest in a limited ceasefire involving energy-related targets, U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on Wednesday after meeting Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov in New York. However, Russia has given no public indication it is ready to agree to such arrangements. REUTERS

LONDON

U.K. to launch new military space squadron to protect its satellites



Britain announced on Wednesday that it will launch a new military space squadron charged with defending the country's satellites, in the latest move as various countries rush for military space capabilities. The new Royal Air Force (RAF) squadron will protect critical satellites used in communications. AFP

SANAA

Houthi to target U.S. interests if it supports Saudi-led strikes: adviser



Houthi military adviser Abed Mohammed al-Thawri said that the group would attack U.S. interests in the West Asia if Washington intervenes in Yemen's conflict in support of Saudi Arabia or tries to unblock the Bab el-Mandeb strait. Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman had requested help from U.S. President Trump. AFP

First shuttle talks between U.S., Iran in months raise hopes for progress

Iranian Minister Araghchi and U.S. envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner communicate through mediators on sidelines of UN General Assembly; the diplomatic contact in New York causes backlash in Iranian media associated with hardliners

Reuters
UNITED NATIONS/DUBAI

The first shuttle talks between the United States and Iran for months raised hopes on Wednesday that the adversaries could make progress towards ending the West Asia war, although neither side spelled out any change in its position. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi and U.S. envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner communicated through mediators on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly in New York, the first such contacts since an interim ceasefire agreement collapsed in July.



Abbas Araghchi meets with Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani on the sidelines of 81st UN General Assembly. REUTERS

"Steve and Jared had a very productive meeting today with mediators of Iran," U.S. President Donald Trump said. "I think there's a lot of momentum for them to make a deal.

It's what we're hearing from everybody." Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baqaei said Tehran had engaged with the U.S. through a Qatari mediator

in New York and conveyed conditions, including an end to the war on all fronts and a halt to U.S. "acts of aggression". Some Iranian state media had earlier reported that Mr. Araghchi and Mr. Witkoff had met, but Iranian officials clarified that it was not face-to-face. Mr. Araghchi met the Prime Minister of Qatar, Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman Al Thani, one of the main mediators at previous talks. 'Hardliners resist' The diplomatic contact in New York caused backlash in Iranian media associated with hardliners. An opinion piece run by

the semi-official *Tasnim* news agency, associated with the Revolutionary Guards, said Mr. Araghchi was wrong to have contacts with Mr. Witkoff and Mr. Kushner, as Iran had already conveyed its terms. Iranian sources said that the delegation had been ordered not to meet the Americans face-to-face by the Supreme National Security Council, a body that includes figures selected by Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, the Supreme Leader. One Iranian journalist covering the visit said that some hardliners viewed the trip to New York itself as an insult to the memory of the slain leader, Ali Khamenei.

With Trump-Xi truce, China looks to reshape Asian order

NEWS ANALYSIS
Ananth Krishnan
BEIJING

As U.S. President Donald Trump hosts Chinese President Xi Jinping at the White House on Thursday, the world's two biggest powers appear to be looking to extend their truce. In May, when Mr. Trump visited Beijing, both sides declared their commitment to build a "constructive relationship of strategic stability", a Chinese coinage that the U.S. President, to the surprise of many observers, readily accepted. This week, Mr. Trump is laying the red carpet for Mr. Xi, including by personally welcoming him at Joint Base Andrews, a courtesy he has not extended to any other leader. Optics aside, the expectations for the visit are, however, largely modest on both sides, seen an effort to put a floor on a contentious relationship rather than a grand bargain. This is regardless of Mr. Trump's stated fondness for the idea of a "G2" which has concerned countries in the region, including India. In the weeks after Mr. Trump's visit to Beijing, both sides have traded blows, including the listing of Chinese companies such as Alibaba and BYD by the Pentagon for "civil military fusion", and mutual accusations over how the other side is conducting the AI race. Other sticking points remain unresolved, such as tariffs, restrictions on semiconductors and Chinese export controls, especially on rare earths. China is also pressing the U.S. to



Donald Trump speaks with Xi Jinping while leaving after a visit to the Zhongnanhai Garden in Beijing, China, in May. REUTERS

stop arms sales to Taiwan. If this has led some observers to suggest this truce is merely a tactical pause while each side works towards reducing their vulnerabilities and building leverage, others argue there are compelling reasons for both powers to pursue a future relationship of stability. Writing in *Foreign Affairs* before the visit, Da Wei, a leading voice in Beijing on the China-U.S. relationship and Director of the Center for International Security and Strategy at Tsinghua University, made the case for why despite structural challenges, there were reasons for both to pursue a detente. "The rapid development of technologies such as AI will make it particularly difficult for either the U.S. or China to eliminate the other's sources of leverage," he said. In the lead up to the visit, the two sides held talks in New York between Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng, including to set up a dialogue mechanism for AI cooperation. The broader reason for a continued truce, in the view of Da Wei, was the narrowing power differential between the two coun-

tries. "China is looking at bilateral relations from a position of greater equality and with more confidence," he said. "It is less anxious that competition will undermine its national development prospects. Instead, Beijing believes that competition can be effectively managed without presenting an existential threat." For other Chinese strategists, the longer term goal is a grand bargain that will gradually see declining U.S. interest in Asia and a reshaped Asian security order. The view in Beijing is that Mr. Trump has already initiated that trend. Li Kai, the Vice President of the influential China Institutes for Contemporary International Relations (CICIR) in Beijing, argued in the lead up to Mr. Xi's visit that "regional affairs should be led and managed by Asian countries themselves". "This is consistent with the principle of 'Asian solutions to Asian problems'," he said. "Confronted with an increasingly complex regional security landscape, we must fend off external interference, seek common ground while reserving differences, proactively manage divergences and facilitate peaceful settlement of disputes."

Risk and hope



A group of migrants on a dinghy wave to others still in the water as they try to cross the channel from France to Britain in Hardelet on Wednesday. AP

Pak. shoots down 8 drones 'launched from Afghanistan'

Press Trust of India
ISLAMABAD

Pakistan's security forces on Wednesday shot down eight drones allegedly launched from Afghanistan after they entered Pakistani airspace, security sources said, as new clashes along the border added to tensions between the two neighbouring countries. Four drones were brought down near the Torkham border and another four in mountainous areas near Kohat in northwest Pakistan's Khyber-Pakhtunkhwa province, the sources said. The claims could not be independently verified. Some of the drones were described as rudimentary models, with those detected near Kohat neutralised through a "soft-kill" operation. Afghanistan denied Pakistan's claim, with the Taliban regime rejecting allegations that Afghan Taliban forces had attacked Pakistani positions.

nous areas near Kohat in northwest Pakistan's Khyber-Pakhtunkhwa province, the sources said. The claims could not be independently verified. Some of the drones were described as rudimentary models, with those detected near Kohat neutralised through a "soft-kill" operation. Afghanistan denied Pakistan's claim, with the Taliban regime rejecting allegations that Afghan Taliban forces had attacked Pakistani positions.

Indian sailor killed in attack on ship in the Strait of Hormuz, say authorities

Agence France-Presse
MUSCAT

An attack on a cargo ship in the Strait of Hormuz on Wednesday killed an Indian sailor, Omani and Indian authorities said, with the latter condemning the ongoing attacks in the vital shipping lane. Oman's Maritime Security Centre said in a statement that the Antigua and Barbuda-flagged *Cape Dao* was attacked 2.5 nautical miles off the country's coast "causing a fire in the engine room and leading to the death of one crew member". Twenty-seven crew members were evacuated by the Omani Navy, it added. In a statement, India's External Affairs Ministry condemned the attack on the *Cape Dao*, in which "one Indian national tragi-



Iran has sought to impose its control over the key maritime conduit for Gulf oil and gas since the beginning of the war. AP

cally lost his life", urging the warring parties to return to negotiations. "The targeting of commercial shipping, seafarers, and civilian infrastructure in the region must end, and free and unimpeded navigation and commerce through the international waterways in the region must be restored at the earliest," it added. "My heartfelt condolences to the family of young Indian seafarer, Wiper Suraj Yadav from Uttar Pradesh, who tragically succumbed to head injuries following a missile attack on M.V. *CAPE DAO* off the coast of Oman. The entire nation stands with his family in this hour of grief," Shipping Minister Sarbajit Chatterjee said in a post on X. India is one of the lar-

gest contributors of sailors to merchant shipping worldwide, and several of its mariners have been killed in Hormuz attacks since the war in West Asia began. Oman sits across the Strait of Hormuz from Iran, and ships seeking to skirt Tehran's restrictions have recently been taking a route that hugs the Omani coast. Since the start of the war, Iran has sought to impose its control over the maritime conduit for Gulf oil and gas, occasionally striking ships accused of failing to coordinate with its authorities or deviating from its preferred route. In retaliation, the United States has been enforcing a counter-blockade of Iranian ports, carrying out strikes of its own on ships it says refuse to comply. (With inputs from PTI)

Harvey Weinstein sentenced to 15 years for New York sexual assault

Reuters
NEW YORK

A New York judge sentenced former Hollywood producer Harvey Weinstein to 15 years in prison on Wednesday for sexually assaulting a former production assistant in 2006, following the ex-movie mogul's conviction at a retrial last year. Weinstein, 74, was convicted in June 2025 of first-degree criminal sexual act for assaulting Miriam Haley at his Manhattan apartment on Wednesday for sexually assaulting a former production assistant in 2006, following the ex-movie mogul's conviction at a retrial last year. Weinstein, 74, was convicted in June 2025 of first-degree criminal sexual act for assaulting Miriam Haley at his Manhattan apartment on Wednesday for sexually assaulting a former production assistant in 2006, following the ex-movie mogul's conviction at a retrial last year. 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Returning to roots: Naoero, an eight-square-mile island with about 12,000 people, became independent in 1968. AP

Nauru reclaims ‘Naoero’, sheds its colonial-era name

Associated Press
NEW YORK

His voice forceful and proud, he rose in front of the world’s largest gathering of leaders on behalf of his nation and announced that he had something important to say. The tiny South Pacific island nation of Nauru, its President said, had altered its name – and reclaimed its heritage in the process. “I have travelled far,” David Adeang said Tuesday at the United Nations.

What was known to the world for many years as Nauru, Mr. Adeang said, was returning to the name and pronunciation of its past: Naoero.

“There are moments in the life of a nation when its people are called to remember who they have always been,” Mr. Adeang said in his speech at the UN General Assembly in New York. “This is such a moment for us.”

Though the names are similar and, in essence, the same word, the shift in spelling and pronunciation represents the nation’s effort to recast – rebrand, even – itself for its own people as much as for the outside world. He called it not a change but an effort to “affirm a truth.” “Nauru is how our name sounded to those who find it hard to say, and the world kept it,” Mr. Adeang said.

The nation, an eight-square-mile island with about 12,000 people, became independent in 1968 after long-time colonial rule under the United Kingdom, New Zealand, Australia and Germany. It announced the renaming in August.

The country’s international code is changing from NRU to NRO and its people will be known as dei-Naoero instead of Nauruan. Commonly known abroad by the pronunciation of Now-roo, the new name is spoken as Now-ero.

Associated Press
CAIRO

It took Houthi rebels less than 48 hours to seize Yemen’s Red Sea coast from pro-government forces in a resounding blow to United States’ (U.S.) interests and Washington’s regional allies.

But the Houthis didn’t do it alone. Iranian Revolutionary Guard advisers were in the field helping direct the battle, people familiar with the offensive told AP, marking Iran’s most direct intervention in favour of its longtime ally since Yemen’s civil war erupted in 2014. The intervention shows how Iran has built the Houthis into a major regional partner able to open a new front in the wider war with the U.S.

The rebels’ biggest land grab in years, along with the closure of a key Saudi pipeline, strengthened their ability to choke off Saudi Arabia’s oil exports, pushing up global fuel prices and giving Iran greater leverage. The U.S. has seemed reluctant to help its ally Saudi Arabia, even as the Houthis have gained momentum in Yemen’s revived civil war.

The Houthis’ swift, 115-kilometre (75-mile) assault exploited divisions among forces allied with Yemen’s Saudi-backed, internationally recognised government. The Houthis pene-

trated the internal communications of one of the main forces, the National Resistance, allowing them to track its movements and sow confusion.

As pro-government forces beat a frantic retreat, the leader of the National Resistance fled to Saudi Arabia. The key port city of Mokha was abandoned as residents left in the night, allowing the Houthis to roll in unopposed on September 10. Their seizure of strategic islands nearby further enhanced their ability to attack Saudi oil shipments in the Red Sea.

The Houthis had not conducted a major campaign along the coast since 2017, when government forces drove them out of the area. Since then, the Houthis had focused on trying to capture the oil-rich province of Marib in central Yemen.

A truce took hold in 2022. The following year, the Houthis began attacking Red Sea shipping over the war in Gaza, attacks that continued until a punishing U.S. bombing campaign in 2025. After the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran in February, the Houthis largely kept to the sidelines.

Last year, Iran began providing the Houthis with stepped-up training and logistical support on more advanced missiles, drones and uncrewed attack



Flaring tensions: Houthis had not mounted a major campaign along Red Sea coast since govt. forces drove them out in 2017. AFP

boats, said Mzahem Alsalam, a security analyst who has followed Iranian-backed groups for nearly a decade and now runs a private intelligence firm.

In July, the Houthis renewed their attacks on Saudi Arabia after accusing it of striking the airport in the rebel-held capital, Sanaa. That strike appears to have been aimed at halting a flight from Tehran.

‘Present at all levels’ Mr. Alsalam and a senior Houthi official said the Iranian flight, which later landed, brought Revolutionary Guard advisers, who joined other advisers from the Guard – and Iran’s Lebanese ally, Hezbollah – already based in Yemen.

In early August, the Houthis resumed attacks

on government forces, focusing on the city of Taiz, in the mountains overlooking the coast, and firing missiles and drones at Mokha.

The Houthi official said Iranian advisers had previously focused on strategic planning and were not in the field. But in the latest escalation, they were “present at all levels,” he said, including planning tactical manoeuvres and working with front-line commanders.

Two regional officials also said Iran provided direct support that helped the rapid advance. Mr. Alsalam said that in addition to helping in a command role, the Iranian advisers analysed communications and satellite intelligence, capacities the Houthis were lacking.

The National Resistance, with some 30,000 fighters, was the strongest pro-government force along the coast. But it had not been involved in major fighting since 2017.

For a month, Houthi forces bombarded its positions with 130 ballistic missiles and 145 suicide drones, according to a National Resistance spokesman, Major General Sadiq Dwaid. He said its fighters were stretched over 170 kilometres (100 miles), from Mokha into the mountainous interior, against what he estimated were 75,000 Houthi fighters.

In early September, the Giants Brigade, another militia, came to its aid, helping it to temporarily push back the rebels. But the Giants Brigade had not coordinated with the National Resistance, angering its field commanders, one government official said.

The two forces had a longtime rivalry rooted in the past struggle between Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) over control of the anti-Houthi movement. That struggle led to the UAE abruptly pulling out of Yemen in January.

There was no “unified command,” said the senior military official. “This was a priceless opportunity for the Houthis.” On September 9, the Houthis advanced south toward Mok-

ha through a narrow mountain valley, heavily bombarding their opponents.

Having breached their communications, the Houthis were able to listen in and exploit divisions, one of the government officials said, adding that National Resistance leaders lost contact with several field commanders.

By the afternoon, the Houthis had seized the mountain road and a nearby military base, cutting off government supply lines to Mokha. Lieutenant General Tariq Saleh, the leader of the National Resistance, was forced to flee and then took refuge in Saudi Arabia.

At around 6 p.m. that night, orders went out to National Resistance field units to retreat back to Mokha. When thousands of fighters began arriving, the forces stationed in the port city thought a major Houthi attack was imminent and began to flee, two National Resistance fighters told the AP.

A Mokha resident, Issa Gubwani, said he saw fighters in military vehicles and pickups streaming out of the city. “They left us to face our fate,” he said. Tens of thousands of residents joined the exodus.

The Houthi official said that when the rebels rolled in early on September 10, “the city was empty.”

Moroccans vote for new Parliament with lack of jobs, inequality in focus

Associated Press
CASABLANCA

Moroccans are voting for a new Parliament Wednesday in an election shaped by mounting frustration among young people, high unemployment despite a thriving economy, and demands for better schools, hospitals and housing.

Voting centres across the North African kingdom were open from 8 a.m. to 7 p.m. local time, allowing nearly 16 million registered voters to cast ballots for the 395-seat House of Representatives.

The election is the first since deadly youth-led protests nearly a year ago and a mass attempt by migrants to cross Morocco’s northern border into the



No single party is expected to obtain an absolute majority even as voters choose among 7,288 candidates from 27 political parties. AP

Spanish territory of Ceuta that left dozens dead.

The vote will determine the next Prime Minister and the makeup of the government, which will serve alongside a powerful monarchy that retains broad authority over strategic affairs.

Results are expected Thursday.

The next government will oversee billions of dollars in investment as Morocco prepares to co-host the 2030 FIFA World Cup, prompting some to describe it as the “World Cup government.”

The new political leadership will also face pressure to address everyday concerns, including jobs,

wages and the cost of living. For many young Moroccans, the election comes as doubts grow that political participation can improve their daily lives.

Some have turned to street protests, while others have considered leaving the country or staying away from the ballot box.

Voters will choose among 7,288 candidates from 27 political parties.

No single party is expected to obtain an absolute majority, the winner will need to negotiate with others to form a governing coalition.

Some, including the far-left party The Democratic Path, called to boycott the election saying that it “lacks the minimum conditions of democracy.”

Bitter harvest



Lost labour: A Palestinian man holds a handful of olives from a tree uprooted by the Israeli military in his field in Deir Nidham, northwest of Ramallah in the Israeli-occupied West Bank, on Wednesday. AFP

Putin becoming more cavalier and open to risk, warns senior NATO commander

Associated Press
TALLINN

Russian President Vladimir Putin is becoming “increasingly cavalier, dangerous and risk accepting,” as his war in Ukraine drags on and as he seeks to divide Western allies, NATO’s deputy commander in Europe said Tuesday.

Air Chief Marshal Sir John Stringer spoke to AP at a security conference in Estonia amid warnings from some European leaders that Moscow is planning to test NATO’s collective defence pact with bolder attacks that have already included sabotage and espionage.

Mr. Stringer warned that NATO members need to be aware of the “febrile environment” and be careful in their response because Mr. Putin would like to pro-

voke the alliance into an “overreaction.”

Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk said last week that Russia might target NATO nations with deliberate drone or missile strikes while claiming they were accidental. French President Emmanuel Macron agreed and has asked his government to prepare a plan to protect critical infrastructure against potential drone attacks and cyberattacks.

Other European officials say the threat from Russia is serious but have called for calm.

A British defence official said the U.K. assessment is that Mr. Putin is not seeking direct confrontation with NATO. Officials in Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania, which border Russia, also have been more cautious about the prospect of

a serious escalation after years of calling on Western nations to adopt a more hawkish approach to Moscow.

“Ukraine is fighting. Russia is absorbed in Ukraine. We do not observe any buildup near our borders. And from that part, I think that most would agree that the perspective of direct military attack is not correct,” Latvian President Edgars Rinkevics told reporters late Tuesday on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly in New York.

The U.S. ambassador to NATO, Matthew Whitaker, dismissed any concerns that Russia may be testing the transatlantic military alliance, telling AP following a panel discussion in Des Moines, Iowa, on Tuesday evening that “Putin does not want a conflict



European nations have already faced several incursions of Russian drones, and other disruptions since Putin’s invasion of Ukraine. AFP

with NATO.”

He said drone incursions into countries like Romania or Poland were largely the result of electronic warfare and unintentional but noted that hybrid activities like sabotage “are more concerning.”

Mr. Whitaker also warned against “overreacting” because “that’s exactly what I think our adversaries would want or hope for.”

European countries have already faced multiple incursions of Russian drones – and several missiles – as well as a campaign of covert Russian disruption which began after Mr. Putin’s invasion of Ukraine.

An AP interactive map tracking that campaign shows the escalation, from 59 incidents in March 2025 to more than 210 incidents

ranging from vandalism, propaganda and influence operations to arson, sabotage and cyberattacks.

NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte told AP in Iowa that Mr. Putin “knows that the United States and Europe are totally intertwined.” “We have to make sure that we are prepared, we are strong, and he knows it. And if he does anything silly, he knows our reaction will be tough,” Mr. Rutte said.

A fine line

In August, German officials accused Moscow of being behind a plot at Leipzig airport where a drone with explosives was found next to a Ukrainian plane laden with jet fuel. Last month, British officials said they disrupted a Russian plot to sabotage a drone factory outside London. In August,

an Estonian defence company was set on fire and a weapons storage facility in Bulgaria exploded, though neither has been publicly attributed to Russia.

Many saboteurs have been recruited online by Russia’s intelligence services and some have no idea they are working for Moscow. That makes uncovering a plot challenging and attribution often difficult. When asked by AP in May if Russia was waging a covert campaign against the West, Mr. Putin responded: “Name one proven fact.”

The line between “accidental and deliberate is quite a fine one,” Mr. Stringer said, referring to incursions of drones sent off course into NATO airspace by Russian GPS jamming or other electronic countermeasures to defend

against Ukrainian drone strikes.

It would be possible for Russia to escalate that activity but it does not mean Moscow has decided to do so, said Mr. Stringer, NATO’s deputy supreme allied commander for Europe.

While there are “a lot of different opinions as to how acute the threat is... Russia’s attitude towards negligence” and deliberately targeting NATO neighbours “is almost the same,” Estonian Prime Minister Kristen Michal told AP at the security conference.

Both Mr. Stringer and Mr. Michal suggested the increase in attacks by Moscow was not because of a failure by NATO nations to stop them but as a direct consequence of Western support for Ukraine.

SURREAL

This time I have fulfilled my Asian Games dream: Mirabai



PTI

I have dreamt of winning an Asian Games medal ever since I stepped into weightlifting. Something or the other happened before or during the Games, but this time I have fulfilled my dream. I am yet to decide on how to go about LA 2028. I will enjoy this medal for a while and then decide — Mirabai Chanu after winning silver.

BREAKING THROUGH

Jay Meena wins India's first-ever medal in soft tennis at Asiad



X@SAI

Jay Meena won India's first-ever soft tennis medal at the Asian Games, fetching a bronze after losing to Takuya Kurosaka in the men's singles semifinals. Taking part in his third Asiad, the 26-year-old produced a spirited fightback before losing 2-4 (3-5, 1-4, 1-4, 4-1, 6-4, 1-4) to the Japanese in a 45-minute clash.

NO SWEAT

Deepika scores nine as India women thrash Thailand



AHF

In-form drag-flicker Deepika Sehrawat extended her impressive run, scoring a record nine goals, as India thrashed Thailand 20-1 to register its third consecutive victory in Pool B of the Asian Games women's hockey competition in Kakamigahara on Wednesday. India, which is leading the group, will next play Japan on Friday.

GOLD IN SIGHT

Roshibina prevails over Thania, enters wushu summit clash



PTI

Indian wushu player Roshibina Devi, in red, will fight for gold at the Asian Games after defeating Indonesia's Thania Kusumaningtyas in the women's 60kg category in Nagoya on Wednesday. Roshibina, who prevailed 2-0 in the last-four contest at the Aichi Prefectural Martial Arts Hall, will face China's Xiaoyu Zhang in the summit clash.

Mirabai lifts silver, ends long wait for Asian Games medal

A total of 198kg helps the icon finish behind North Korea's Gum, who completes a hat-trick of titles with a World record 215kg effort; dream finally turns into reality for the 32-year-old Indian

ASIAN GAMES

Jonathan Selvaraj
NAGOYA

Mirabai Chanu's place in the pantheon of Indian sporting greats was already secure. Olympic silver, World championship gold and multiple Commonwealth Games golds had ensured that.

So, just how much could an Asian Games medal matter? It turns out that it mattered to her for close to a decade and a half.

"I was thinking that I've won medals at the Olympics, World championships and Asian championships. Why can't I just win a medal at the Asian Games? I've been trying since 2014 but wasn't able to," said Mirabai after the final of the 49kg category.

North Korea's Ri Song Gum was in a class of her own. She won her third consecutive Asian Games gold and broke her own



Weight off her shoulders: Mirabai beams with joy and pride after winning a medal at the Asian Games for the first time in her illustrious career. AP

World record with a total of 215kg. The precocious Vijayana Diana, just 21, edged ahead of Mirabai after snatch, lifting 88kg to the Indian's 87kg. But in

clean and jerk, Mirabai's strength made the difference. She had 107kg and 111kg while the Indonesian's best was 103kg. Mirabai's total of 198kg was

enough for silver; she didn't even need a final attempt. It was the medal she had chased for eternity. The obsession finally became reality.

Mixed bag for India at shooting range

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The Aichi General Shooting Range continued to reward Indian shooters with medals at the Asian Games here on Wednesday, just not the colour they desperately want; or the events that they expected to win in. The men's and women's skeet teams both finished third for a bronze while two of the three shooters in the final — Anantjeet Singh Naruka and Raiza Dhillon — fell agonisingly short, finishing fourth. Parinaaz Dhalwal finished eighth in the individual event as India's wait for a shooting gold continues.

The shotgun arena made up for the disaster inside the firing range where Esha Singh and Suruchi Phogat had forgettable outings in the qualifying and failed to make the cut for the final while Manu Bhaker bowed out fifth in the 10m air pistol, an event the three of them have been dominating.

Naruka, the silver medalist from Hangzhou, missed two of his first four shots and despite trying his best, was unable to overturn the deficit.

In a field where the smallest of margins meant



Fruitful outing: The men's team of Mairaj, Naruka and Bhavtegh and the women's trio of Raiza, Maheshwari and Parinaaz made it to the podium. R.V. MOORTHY

survival or elimination, it was not so much Naruka misfiring as his competitors not faltering. He scored 25 out of 28 shots, one behind bronze medalist Lee Meng-Yuan of Taiwan. Among the women, Raiza ended with 23 out of 28 while Parinaaz was the first to be eliminated.

Earlier, the men — Mairaj Ahmed Khan and Bhavtegh Gill along with Naruka — totalled 346 over three days of qualifying rounds to finish behind Qatar (353) and Kuwait (348).

The women's trio of Raiza, Parinaaz and Maheshwari Chauhan totalled 331 in the qualifying to finish

third behind China (357) and Kazakhstan (336) for the first-ever Asian Games medal in women's skeet.

"It's a great feeling knowing that [we are the first] but I think the girls were in great form and I am hoping we will go with a few more medals, a little disappointed it not being a better colour," Maheshwari said. "The reason [for shotgun taking a backseat] is because we just didn't have high performing athletes and enough female athletes to begin with."

In pistol, Manu finished her qualifying round with 579 in third position. Esha began with series of 94 and 93 before picking up pace but a 95 and 96 in the last four series was never going to be enough, as she finished with 572 points with 12x. Suruchi, meanwhile, had three series of 94 each and one of 93 for a total of 568 with 12x to finish 26th.

In the final, Manu never really got going, starting with a 9.9 and ending with a 9.6 and just two 10.8s throughout her series of 18 shots. The biggest setback was an 8.9 on her eighth shot, which pushed her down into elimination zone and although she kept surviving, it was a matter of evading the inevitable.

'Feels like life is complete'

Jonathan Selvaraj
NAGOYA

Asian athletes have dominated the women's 48kg and 49kg weight divisions for 25 years, winning 27 of 30 Olympic medals and holding all World records. And so, the desperation for an Asian Games medal is understandable for India's Mirabai Chanu.

"I'm feeling so happy... so light. *Bilkul weight hat gaya hai* (the weight has lifted completely)," she said after the win.

In the Hangzhou Asiad of 2023, Mirabai knew she had tweaked her hip during warm-up, but she gritted her teeth and loaded 117kg on the bar — the second-most she had ever attempted — as she bid for bronze.

However, she collapsed and had to be carried off stage. Previously, she'd fal-



Winning smile: Mirabai added another silver to her collection. AP

len short in Incheon 2014 and missed the 2018 Jakarta edition with injury.

When the lightest Olympic weight division moved to 53kg, Mirabai — rather than bulking up for the LA Games after missing out at Paris — kept her weight down to focus on the podi-

um in Nagoya.

"I had to work so hard to preserve myself to maintain my weight but this was so important for me."

With a silver medal in hand now, she exclaimed, "It feels *ki life complete ho gaya* (It feels like life is complete)," she said.



Tough going: Manu felt really sorry for not being able to win a medal in the 10m air pistol event. R.V. MOORTHY

Manu shooting through tears and challenges

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Manu Bhaker has had a rough two years since the Paris Olympics high, both on and off the range. The 24-year-old has had a couple of podium finishes in both 10m and 25m pistol each, a far cry from her own high standards, but it's the sudden death of coach, mentor and father-figure Jaspal Rana earlier this year that really broke her.

The Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games is her first competitive outing since Rana's passing and, expectedly, it wasn't easy for the youngster. Talking to the media after her fifth-place finish in the 10m air pistol, Manu began bravely, talking about the match before a mention of Rana finally broke open the shell.

"Of course I miss him, he was the best of the best, the Asian champion. When it came to Asian Games, I think he was the undisputed champion and we were really looking forward to

Japan," she started before getting overwhelmed. Eyes welling up, unable to speak, she walked away, the floodgates finally making way for a torrent of tears gushing down her face.

It took a few minutes but she returned and her composure and decision to complete the interaction was perhaps the biggest hat-tip to Rana, ever the professional.

Talk about shooting and Wednesday's performance brought back a semblance of normality. "I genuinely tried my best and I really feel the performance was significantly better than the challenges I have been facing in my training in Japan. I feel really sorry I was not able to make it to the podium, I hope I will be able to do better," she said.

The training challenges she mentioned included sunlight affecting her focus during the pre-event training and inability to see the sides but she insisted that she was focused on the process.

THE INDIA SHOW

A look at some Indian performances on Wednesday:

- Badminton:** Men's team (semifinal): lost to China 1-3, bagged bronze.
- Boxing:** Men's 80kg (round-of-16): Ankush bt Hamsa (Brn).
- Fencing:** Table-of-16: Men's sabre individual: Gisho lost to Sarkissyan (Kaz) 11-15; Table-of-32: Men's sabre individual: Karan lost to Luo (Chn) 14-15; Women's foil individual: Ashitha lost to Gnoyeva (Kaz) 14-15; Mina lost to Jihee (Kor) 3-15.
- Hockey:** Women (Pool B): bt Thailand 20-1.
- Kabaddi:** Women (Group A): bt Iran 37-23; Men (Group A): bt Bangladesh 48-25.
- Shooting:** Finals: Women: 10m air pistol individual: Manu (fifth); Team: Fourth (Manu, Esha, Suruchi); Skeet individual: Raiza (fourth), Parinaaz (eighth); Team: Bronze (Raiza, Parinaaz, Maheshwari); Men: Skeet individual: Anantjeet (fourth); Team: Bronze (Anantjeet, Mairaj, Bhavtegh).
- Soft tennis:** Men (semifinal): Jay lost to Kurosaka (Jpn) 2-4, clinched bronze.
- Squash:** Round-of-32: Men: Abhay bt Arkarahirunya (Tha) 3-0; Veer bt Wakeel (SL) 3-0; Women: Tanvi bt Dami (Kor) 3-0.
- Swimming:** Men: 100m butterfly: Benedicton (13th overall), DNQ for final; 200m freestyle: Aneesh (17th overall) and Vedaant (19th overall), DNQ for final.
- Table tennis:** Mixed doubles (round-of-16): Harmeet & Yashaswini bt To & Lam (Hkg) 3-1; Manush & Diya bt Moosa & Aishath (Mdv) 3-0.
- Weightlifting:** Women: Final: 49kg: Mirabai (silver); 53kg: Gyaneshwari (eighth).
- Wushu:** Women's 60kg sanda semifinal: Roshibina bt Thania (Ina).



Falling short: While Satwik and Chirag did their job in doubles, the others faltered. REUTERS

Indian men shuttlers finish with a bronze after loss to China

Press Trust of India
NAGOYA

Satwiksairaj Rankiredy and Chirag Shetty won their doubles match but Lakshya Sen and Ayush Shetty faltered against higher-ranked opponents as the Indian men's team signed off with a bronze medal after losing 1-3 to China in the Asian Games semifinals here on Wednesday.

India had won silver at the last edition in Hangzhou, where it had lost to China in the final.

World No. 14 Lakshya, who had produced a stirring performance to take India to the semifinals, could not quite bring his A game, going down 16-21, 18-21 to world No. 6 Shi Yu Qi in the first singles.

Satwiksairaj and Chirag then produced a sensational performance to outwit

reigning world champions Liang Wei Keng and Wang Chang 21-11, 22-20 to bring India back into the five-match tie.

A lot rode on young Ayush, but the world No. 20 could not maintain the required discipline and lost 19-21, 13-21 to world No. 12 Li Shi Feng in the second singles.

The responsibility to keep India afloat then fell on Hariharan Amsakarunan and M.R. Arjun, who took on the scratch pair of He Ji Ting and Liu Yi in the second doubles but they lost 16-21, 21-17, 9-21.

The results (semifinals): China 3 bt India 1 (Shi Yu Qi bt Lakshya Sen 21-16, 21-18; Liang Wei Keng & Wang Chang lost to Satwiksairaj Rankiredy & Chirag Shetty 11-21, 20-22; Li Shi Feng bt Ayush Shetty 21-19, 21-13; He Ji Ting & Liu Yi bt Hariharan Amsakarunan & M.R. Arjun 21-16, 17-21, 21-9).

INBRIEF



Bumrah and Hardik will be important in SA: Gambhir

With the upcoming West Indies ODIs at home, India will start its preparations for next year’s 2027 World Cup in South Africa without Jasprit Bumrah (on Asian Games duty) and Hardik Pandya (still not fit to bowl 10 overs in ODIs). Head coach Gambhir said both seniors are very important in India’s ODI scheme of things. “Both of them are going to be extremely important for us in South Africa. Very few teams have a player like Hardik who can bowl 10 overs for you, plus bat at No. 6 or 7 with that impact. There are no ifs and buts going to World Cup,” Gambhir said.

Brook and Jacks power England past SL in first ODI

England extended its white-ball dominance over Sri Lanka by winning the first ODI at Chester-Le-Street on Tuesday by 89 runs on the back of a 67 by captain Harry Brook and a five-wicket haul by part-time spinner Will Jacks. It comes after England won the T20I series between the countries 3-0 last week. Jacks had also contributed with the bat by providing crucial late-innings runs for England with 46 not out before the hosts were restricted to 265. Contributions also came from opener Ben Duckett (32), Joe Root (44) and Jos Buttler (31).

The scores: England 265 in 48.1 overs (Brook 67, Jacks 46 n.o., Root 44, Colombage 3/44) bt Sri Lanka 176 in 37 overs (Wellalage 45, Kusal 42, Jacks 5/22).
Toss: England. **PoM:** Jacks.

Mohali to host India-A vs. Australia-A women’s game

The only red-ball fixture between India-A women and Australia-A women beginning September 29 was, on Wednesday, moved to Mohali from Dharamshala after the rainy season damaged the outfield. “The Multi-Day fixture between India-A Women and Australia-A Women, scheduled to be played from September 29 to October 2, 2026, has been shifted from Dharamshala to Mohali. The venue change has been necessitated due to the impact of prolonged rainfall in Dharamshala on the outfield and the prevailing ground conditions,” said the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) in a release.



Sports media professional Naveen Peter passes away

Naveen Peter, a sports media professional, passed away in Mumbai in the wee hours of Wednesday. He was 34. For almost a decade, Naveen was the digital head of a sports content company, which was in charge of the Olympics.com’s India content. Prior to that, Naveen, an alumnus of the Asian College of Journalism in Chennai, had stints as a sports journalist with *Deccan Herald* and *Deccan Chronicle*.

Indian tennis player Somani gets four-year ban for doping

Indian tennis player Parikshit Somani was banned for four years (till September 2029) in a doping case on Wednesday after judges dismissed an explanation he gave that was similar to the case of Russian figure skater Kamila Valieva. The 26-year-old Somani tested positive for trimetazidine at a lower-tier event last year in Astana, Kazakhstan.

Aronian, Abhimanyu join field for Total Chess pilot event

A total of 24 elite players, including three Indians, will compete in the official pilot event of the Total Chess World Championship Tour in Budapest from November 10 to 20. Organisers said Levon Aronian, Jorden van Foreest, Abhimanyu Mishra and three others had been added to the line-up. The field, led by World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen, includes R. Praggnanandhaa, Arjun Erigaisi and R. Vaishali, apart from Fabiano Caruana, Vincent Keymer and Anish Giri. Total Chess is a FIDE-approved global event conceptualised by Norway Chess.

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Tajinderpal Singh Toor might have missed a chance to carry the Indian flag at the opening ceremony but the star shot-putter remains a favourite to raise it for the third consecutive time at the Asian Games as the track and field events kick off at the Paloma Mizuho Stadium here on Thursday. While athletics icon Neeraj Chopra had a premature end to his season due to injury, Tajinderpal will be a certainty to finish on top. A two-time defending champion, the 31-year-old would be hoping to complete his hat-trick of gold medals and enter the history books as the first-ever Indian track and field athlete to stand on top of podium thrice in a row in a single event.



Strong contender: Tajinderpal will dig deep into his reservoir of experience to finish top of the podium. PTI

In the absence of Neeraj, Rohit Yadav and Yashvir will look to ensure an Indian among javelin medallists. Both have crossed

85m this season although the gold is likely to go to Sri Lankan Rumesh Pathirage, who has been the man to beat this year with three

throws beyond 90m and tops the season’s World list.

Among those looking to better the colour of their

Indian open team back to winning ways; women outclass Germany

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

The rest day seemed to have helped both the Indian teams at the Chess Olympiad in Samarkand. The defending champion India scored badly-needed wins in the open and women’s sections in the seventh round on Wednesday.

After the loss to host Uzbekistan in the previous round -- their first in the tournament -- the Indian men should be relieved that they could defeat England 2.5-1.5.

Nihal loses again
It was the wins by R. Praggnanandhaa and D. Gukesh over Nikita Vitiugov and Daniel Howard Fernandez respectively that nullified Nihal Sarin’s second straight defeat, this time to Luke McShane.

Arjun Erigaisi drew with Michael Adams.

Uzbekistan has maintained its sole lead after scoring a crucial 3-1 win over China.

The home team has 12 match points, two more than India and four others -- the Netherlands, Germa-



Third eye: Gukesh follows the women’s match after his win.



Dominant show: Divya played her part in India’s facile victory over Germany. FIDE

ny, Azerbaijan and Armenia.

In the women’s event too, India is in joint second place, but just one point less than the leaders China

and Kazakhstan who have 13 each. India is tied for the second position with Bulgaria, Georgia, Armenia and Mongolia.

Four rounds remain.

The Indian women should take a lot of confidence in to their remaining matches after their crushing 3.5-0.5 win against Germany. Koneru Humpy,

Divya Deshmukh and B. Savitha Shri all won their games, while R. Vaishali drew.

The results (seventh round):
Open: India bt England 2.5-1.5 (R. Praggnanandhaa bt Nikita Vitiugov; Arjun Erigaisi drew with Michael Adams; Nihal Sarin lost to Luke McShane; D. Gukesh bt Daniel Howard Fernandez).

Uzbekistan bt China 3-1; Armenia drew with USA 2-2; Germany bt Turkiye 3-1; Netherlands bt Bulgaria 3.5-0.5; Azerbaijan bt Greece 3.5-0.5; France drew with Uzbekistan (2) 2-2; Hungary bt Australia 2.5-1.5; Serbia bt Kazakhstan 3.5-0.5; Poland bt Sweden 2.5-1.5; Slovakia bt Iran 2.5-1.5; Czech Republic bt Lithuania 2.5-1.5.

Women: India bt Germany 3.5-0.5 (Koneru Humpy bt Dinara Wagner; R. Vaishali drew with Elisabeth Paehtz; Divya Deshmukh bt Hanna Marie Klek; B. Savitha Shri bt Lara Schultze). Uzbekistan bt Slovenia 3.5-0.5; China drew with Kazakhstan 2-2; Georgia bt Poland 2.5-1.5; Bulgaria bt Ukraine 3-1; Armenia bt Azerbaijan 2.5-1.5; Mongolia bt France 2.5.1.5; USA bt Switzerland 3-1; Netherlands bt Turkiye 3.5-0.5; Cuba drew with Serbia 2-2; Canada bt Hungary 2-2.



Magnetic presence: Indian All Stars players try to take the ball off Ronaldinho. THULASI KAKKAT

Brazil Legends thrill the crowd during win

FOOTBALL

P.K. Ajith Kumar
KOCHI

Long before kick-off, the fans thronged the Jawahar-lal Nehru Stadium. Many of them wore the blue shirt of India, and there were several in yellow, too.

Hawkers were there as well, selling jerseys and plastic horns. And if you wanted, you could get the flags of India or Brazil painted on your face. There was indeed excitement in the air on Wednesday night. You would be pardoned if you thought the build-up was for a competitive match, and not the one featuring former football stars. The legends from Brazil didn’t disap-

point their fans.

And there were quite a few goals, too. In the match dubbed the Return of the Titans, Brazil Legends beat Indian All Stars 4-3.

The highlight was an old-fashioned hat-trick by Fernandinho, who was superb right through. Brazil’s other goal was scored by the man most people came to watch – Ronaldinho. The winner of the Ballon d’Or in 2005 scored from the penalty spot. And it was a nice, firm kick.

He wasn’t the only player on the field to have won the Ballon d’Or and World Cup. There was Rivaldo, too. C.K. Vineeth netted two goals, including the one that gave the home team a 1-0 lead. The other was scored in the dying minutes by Ashim Biswas.

SNAPSHOTS

Milne, Bracewell back in New Zealand squad for India T20Is

WELLINGTON: New Zealand speedster Adam Milne will return to the Black Caps T20I squad for next month’s home series against India after more than a year out of international cricket, coach Rob Walter said on Wednesday.

Thirteen of the 16-strong squad were part of the New Zealand side that finished runner-up to India at the T20 World Cup in March.

Milne, 34, last played for New Zealand more than a year ago.

The squad: Mitchell Santner (Capt.), Finn Allen, Michael Bracewell, Mark Chapman, Devon Conway, Jacob Duffy, Lockie Ferguson, Zak Foulkes, Matt Henry, Bevon Jacobs, Kyle Jamieson, Adam Milne, Daryl Mitchell, Glenn Phillips, Tim

Seifert and Nathan Smith.

Moliya to lead Rest of India u-23 against TN
Priyanshu Moliya will lead the 15-member Rest of India u-23 squad against Col. C.K. Nayudu Trophy champion Tamil Nadu in a four-day match, to be held at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium, here from October 1 to 4.

The squad, picked by the BCCI junior cricket committee, has Angkrish Raghuvanshi as vice-captain, while Aravelly Avanish Rao and Mayank Verma are the two wicketkeepers.

The squad: Priyanshu Moliya (Capt.), Angkrish Raghuvanshi (Vice-capt.), Ayush Jethwa, Manan Bhat, Digvijay Patil, Raxit Mehta, Aravelly Avanish Rao (wk), Mayank Verma (wk), Emanjot Singh Chahal, Chandraraj Rathod, Varun Singh Bhuie, Ganesh Suthar, Nikhil Giri, Chetan Sharma, and G. Sumith.

Anupama aims for glory in billiards at Commonwealth championship

Tarun Shastry
CHENNAI

After a semifinal finish in the UK Women’s Snooker Championship earlier this month, Anupama Ramachandran is turning her attention to billiards.

The reigning IBSF World Snooker champion will lead India’s challenge in English billiards at the Commonwealth Cue Sports Championships, to be held in Ahmedabad from October 7 to 10.

“I’ve been playing a couple of snooker tournaments and did well in the event in the UK, I’ve been feeling more confident and feel that I’m in good touch,” Anupama told *The Hindu* in a virtual interaction. “Obviously, I’m playing billiards, which is a lit-



Anupama. FILE PHOTO

tle different. Although the games are similar, they require different skills and a different thought process. So, I’ll have to put in the hours on the billiards table.”

The 23-year-old has also been testing herself in Heyball over the last year and a half, competing at the



I was struggling a little with my timing and cueing, and Yasin sir helped me make a few changes

Asian and World championships.

“Because I’ve played snooker, the potting aspect does help me. But there’s a lot of tactical play and the way you think about the game is a little different. It’s about playing more and gaining experience,” she said.

For Anupama, the Ahmedabad event also represents a significant step for cue sports in the country, particularly with billiards being included in the

Commonwealth. “India has a great legacy in billiards with the likes of Wilson Jones, Michael Ferreira, Geet Sethi and Pankaj Advani. We won five medals at the previous edition in Mauritius, and hopefully we can improve on that this time.”

Anupama has also been fine-tuning her technique under former Asian champion Yasin Merchant, with particular emphasis on her timing and cueing.

“I was struggling a little with my timing and cueing, and Yasin sir helped me make a few changes. It’s a slow process, but I can already see the difference in my game. I feel more comfortable with my timing and my shots now, and that has been the major change,” she said.

